



CITY OF AMSTERDAM

Smart Growth Comprehensive Plan 2026

DRAFT
FEBRUARY
2026



01

Introduction

An introduction to the purpose and principles guiding this plan.



INTRODUCTION

What is this Plan?

This Comprehensive Plan is the official guide for the City's planning efforts and decision-making over the next decade.

Purpose

The Comprehensive Plan is one of the most important policy tools a community can implement. The intention of the Comprehensive Plan is to document a community's existing conditions, identify the community's future vision, establish goals, and identify a roadmap for future action. The Plan's vision, policies, and objectives serve as a guide for decision-makers and community leaders, and provide a comprehensive development framework to guide future investment.

Amsterdam's Plan will guide decision-making in a number of areas, including:

- ✓ **Land Use and Zoning:** The Plan will guide decisions about growth and development patterns across the city.
- ✓ **Budgeting and Grant Acquisitions:** The Plan will inform the city's annual budget and will make the city more competitive for state and federal grants.
- ✓ **Economic Development:** The Plan will identify priority areas for business growth, workforce needs, and strategies to promote economic opportunity for all.
- ✓ **Housing Strategy:** The Plan will recommend ways to provide diverse housing types and affordability levels to meet current and projected residential needs.
- ✓ **Environmental Protection:** The Plan will establish policies to protect natural resources and promote sustainability and climate resiliency.
- ✓ **Transportation Framework:** The Plan will identify opportunities for connectivity and transportation safety improvements, including options for multi-modal access.
- ✓ **Community Services:** The Plan will project community needs for schools, parks, healthcare, and other public services that support community health and well-being.

Planning Horizon

Because communities evolve over time and their vision may change, comprehensive plans should be updated to ensure that they reflect the current conditions and values of the community. This Plan serves as an update to the City's 2003 Comprehensive Plan, reflecting the changes in values and trends that have occurred over the past two decades. The City's 2024 Comprehensive Plan will have a planning horizon of ten years, up until 2034. This is the length of time for which the 2024 Plan is considered relevant and representative of the community. However, it is recommended that the City review the information contained in this document every one to two years in order to ensure that it is still relevant and beneficial prior to 2034.

City of Amsterdam Map

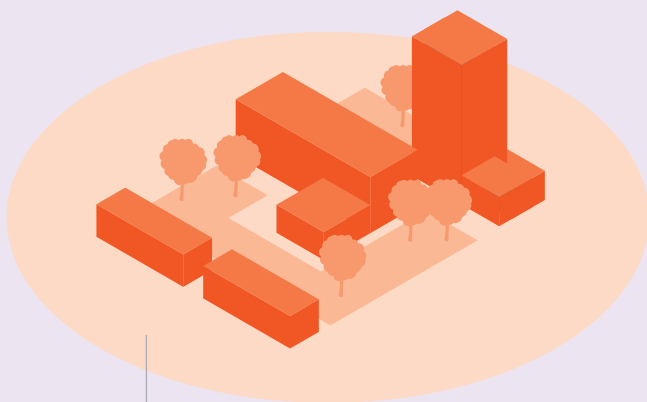


INTRODUCTION

Smart Growth Principles

This Comprehensive Plan uses Smart Growth principles to promote livable, sustainable, and equitable communities.

In alignment with the New York State Department of State (DOS) Smart Growth Program, this plan incorporates “Smart Growth” principles to promote development patterns that are environmentally sustainable, economically efficient, socially equitable, and energy resilient. Smart Growth emphasizes creating compact, walkable neighborhoods with a mix of uses and housing types, while preserving open space and natural resources. Smart Growth employs several land use planning principles to create these kinds of communities, including:



01

Mixed-Use Neighborhoods

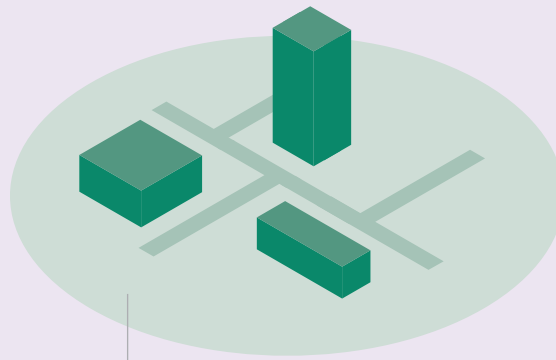
The integration of residential, commercial, and community spaces within neighborhoods creates vibrant, walkable areas where people can live, work, shop, and gather. This approach reduces car dependency and promotes more efficient use of land and infrastructure.



02

Housing Diversity

Providing a range of housing types, sizes, and price points ensures communities can accommodate residents across different income levels, life stages, and household sizes. This includes everything from apartments and townhouses to single-family homes, making neighborhoods more inclusive and economically resilient.



05

Compact Design

Concentrating development in areas with existing infrastructure promotes efficient land use and reduces the costs of providing public services. This principle emphasizes creating walkable neighborhoods with appropriate density that can support local businesses and public transit.



03

Quality Public Spaces

Designing and maintaining accessible parks, plazas, and community gathering spaces provides opportunities for recreation, social interaction, and cultural activities. These spaces should be equitably distributed throughout the community and designed with input from residents.



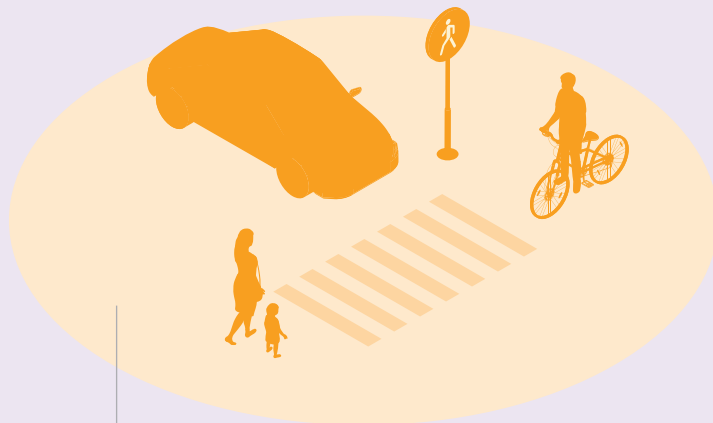
04

Strategic Infill Development

Prioritizing development of vacant or underutilized properties within existing urban areas maximizes the use of existing infrastructure while reducing sprawl. This approach particularly focuses on transit-oriented development, revitalizing areas around transportation hubs to create more connected communities.

INTRODUCTION

Smart Growth Principles



06

Multi-Modal Transportation

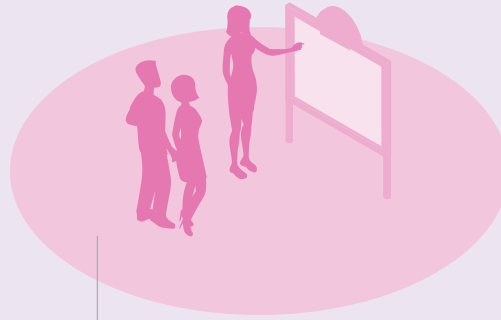
Creating comprehensive transportation networks that prioritize walking, cycling, and public transit reduces car dependency and promotes healthier, more sustainable communities. This includes implementing complete streets policies, expanding bike infrastructure, and improving public transit service.



07

Community Collaboration

Engaging diverse community members in meaningful dialogue about planning decisions through accessible public participation processes ensures plans reflect community needs and values. This requires reaching out to traditionally under-represented groups and providing multiple ways for people to participate in planning processes.



10

Placemaking

Celebrating and enhancing the unique cultural, historical, and architectural characteristics of a community creates distinctive, memorable places that residents value and visitors appreciate. This involves preserving historic buildings, promoting local arts and culture, and ensuring new development complements existing community character.



08

Sustainability & Resiliency

Incorporating climate resilience strategies and greenhouse gas reduction measures into community planning helps protect against climate impacts while reducing environmental harm. This includes using green infrastructure for stormwater management, promoting energy efficiency, and protecting natural systems that provide climate benefits.



09

Resource Preservation

Protecting valuable natural areas, agricultural lands, and open spaces through thoughtful planning and conservation measures ensures environmental sustainability and maintains community character. This includes establishing green corridors, protecting watersheds, and preserving productive farmland.

INTRODUCTION

Existing Plans & Studies

This Comprehensive Plan builds on a number of plans and studies completed across the city and region in recent years.

01 **City of Amsterdam Comprehensive Plan** 2003

The 2003 Comprehensive Plan built upon the 1960 Master Plan's goals and strategies, expanding the Plan's guidance from infrastructure and land use to include additional elements of community and quality of life. The vision of the 2003 Plan was informed by the opportunities and risks facing Amsterdam at that time, which includes several key themes that remain relevant to the city today. This includes goals to:

- Improve Amsterdam's image and identity.
- Rebuild Amsterdam's economic foundation.
- Re-establish downtown as the community center.
- Stabilize and strengthen neighborhoods.
- Promote cultural diversity.
- Align the city more closely with the Capital Region.
- Continue investment in public transit and multi-modal transportation.

02 **Montgomery County Hazard Mitigation Plan** 2024

The Montgomery County Multi-Jurisdictional Hazard Mitigation Plan outlines countywide strategies to reduce vulnerability to natural hazards and strengthen long-term climate resilience. The plan identifies actions that help communities, including Amsterdam, prepare for future climate impacts, protect critical assets, and guide safer development. Key mitigation actions relevant to Amsterdam include:

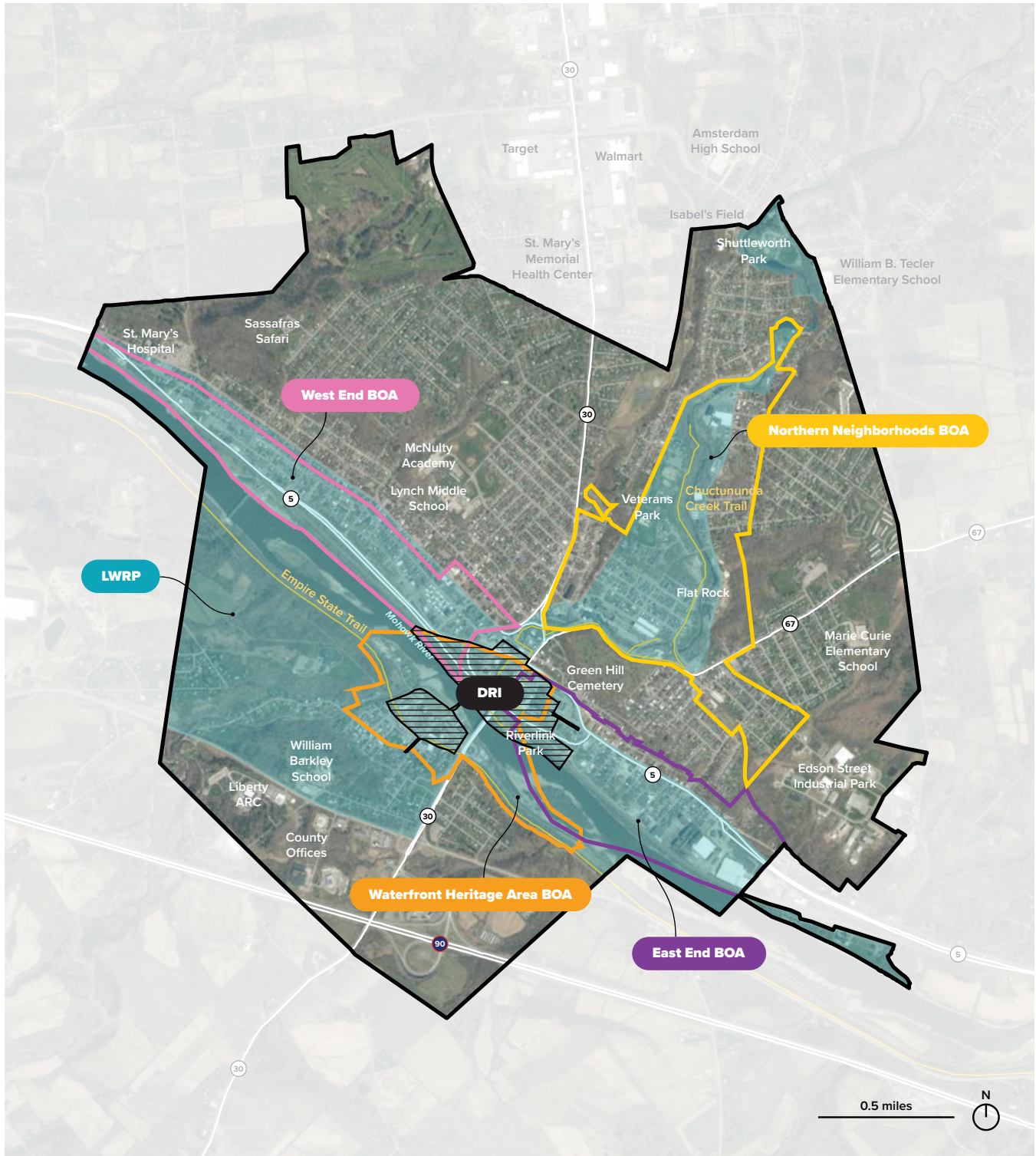
- Updating zoning regulations to improve resiliency in the 100- and 500-year floodplains.
- Pursuing funding for regional and local mitigation projects.
- Reevaluating the installation of a countywide stream gauge system along the Mohawk River and its tributaries to improve flood monitoring.

03 **West End Brownfield Opportunity Area (BOA)** 2024

The West End BOA Nomination Study was developed for a 158-acre area in the city's West End neighborhood, a former manufacturing center now home to approximately 22 brownfield sites. The primary objectives of the BOA study were to determine appropriate reuse options for underutilized and contaminated properties and to generate a catalog of updated information and data necessary to minimize exposure to potential contamination. The study also developed goals specific to the West End neighborhood including:

- Reconnect the West End neighborhood.
- Revive West Main Street with new businesses.
- Provide new recreational and gateway spaces.
- Improve multi-modal transportation and access.
- Expand housing choices.
- Rehabilitate the West End's housing stock and commercial spaces.

Existing Plans Map



- 04 Local Waterfront Revitalization Program (LWRP)**
2023
- The City's Local Waterfront Revitalization Program (LWRP) is a comprehensive land and water use program that expresses a vision for the waterfront area and provides recommendations to achieve that vision. The program includes goals to:
- Continue to redevelop the areas surrounding the Mohawk River and Chuctanunda Creek as dynamic nodes of activity.
 - Increase access to waterfronts.
 - Increase housing supply.
 - Encourage revitalization of the downtown core.
 - Anticipate and mitigate future flood risks.
- 05 East End Brownfield Opportunity Area (BOA)**
2023
- The East End BOA Nomination Study analyzes and provides recommendations to revitalize the East End of Amsterdam, located between the banks of the Mohawk River and Main Street. The overall goals of the study are as follows:
- Reposition Amsterdam's historic real estate for reinvestment.
 - Improve Amsterdam's "front door" image.
 - Create amenities, connect neighborhoods, and provide recreational opportunities for residents and visitors.
- 06 Northern Neighborhoods Brownfield Opportunity Area (BOA)**
2021
- The Northern Neighborhoods BOA Nomination Study examined office, industrial/flex, retail, and multi-family residential real estate development formats to identify possible market-supported opportunities for the reuse or redevelopment of properties within the BOA Study Area. The overall goals of the study are:
- Identify market-feasible opportunities for development.
 - Transform Amsterdam's economy.
 - Increase accessibility throughout the BOA and with adjacent neighborhoods.
 - Revitalize and reinvigorate neighborhoods.
 - Promote healthy lifestyles, tourism and recreation through the development and enhancement of parks, trails, bikeways, greenways, and open spaces.
- 07 Downtown Revitalization Initiative (DRI)**
2019
- In 2019, the City of Amsterdam received a \$10 million grant from New York State to implement a series of projects to revitalize downtown as part of the Downtown Revitalization Initiative (DRI). As part of the DRI process, a set of goals was established to promote downtown revitalization. These goals included:
- Redevelop the Mohawk River and Chuctanunda Creek.
 - Leverage existing historic and cultural resources.
 - Enhance public spaces for arts, cultural, and recreational activities.
 - Develop key components including transportation, housing, recreation, education, employment, and community facilities to work as one.
 - Create an environment that attracts and fosters economic opportunity for a diverse population.
 - Provide a sustainable and diverse range of housing and other uses in the downtown core.

08 Waterfront Heritage Area Brownfield Opportunity Area (BOA)

2015

The Waterfront Heritage Area BOA Nomination Study was prepared for a 104-acre area that included portions of the city's South Side and downtown neighborhoods and the Mohawk River waterfront. This area is characterized by the presence of former mills, brownfields, and a number of vacant and underutilized sites along the waterfront. A number of goals were developed for the area including:

- Revitalize the South Side neighborhood.
- Capitalize on the area's strategic location along the waterfront.
- Create a mix of businesses and residents.
- Establish the area as a cultural heritage destination.
- Unify downtown and the South Side.

09 Mohawk Valley Cleaner, Greener Communities Sustainability Plan

2013

The Cleaner, Greener Communities Sustainability Plan identifies broad goals and specific strategies to achieve a more sustainable future for the Mohawk Valley region. The project goals include:

- Use renewable energy.
- Control sprawl to reduce housing and transportation costs.
- Invest in public transit systems.
- Build stores, schools, and workplaces near neighborhoods.
- Attract businesses to neighborhoods to create jobs and keep dollars local.
- Make walking and bicycling easy to foster healthy lifestyles.
- Reuse developed land to improve economic potential.
- Adopt clean technologies to grow a 21st century economy.
- Conserve resources to strengthen the natural environment.
- Reduce greenhouse gases.

10 NY Rising Community Reconstruction Plan for the City and Town of Amsterdam and Town of Florida

2014

The NY Rising Community Reconstruction (NYRCR) program provided the opportunity for the City of Amsterdam, Town of Amsterdam, and Town of Florida to collectively develop strategies for a more resilient future in light of the impacts of Hurricane Irene. The critical needs identified were:

- Invest in municipal offices to facilitate the continuity of government services during emergency events.
- Develop bilingual emergency alert and preparedness communication materials.
- Create permanent shelter facilities for receiving vulnerable populations and supporting satellite emergency operations during storm events.
- Protect existing healthcare facilities from potential storm impacts.
- Improve stormwater drainage infrastructure.
- Stabilize riverbanks to prevent erosion, including creating greenways and parks to serve both as resiliency infrastructure and community assets.
- Protect cultural resources in flood-prone areas.

02

Our People, Places & Past

A summary of the key physical, social, and economic factors affecting Amsterdam today.



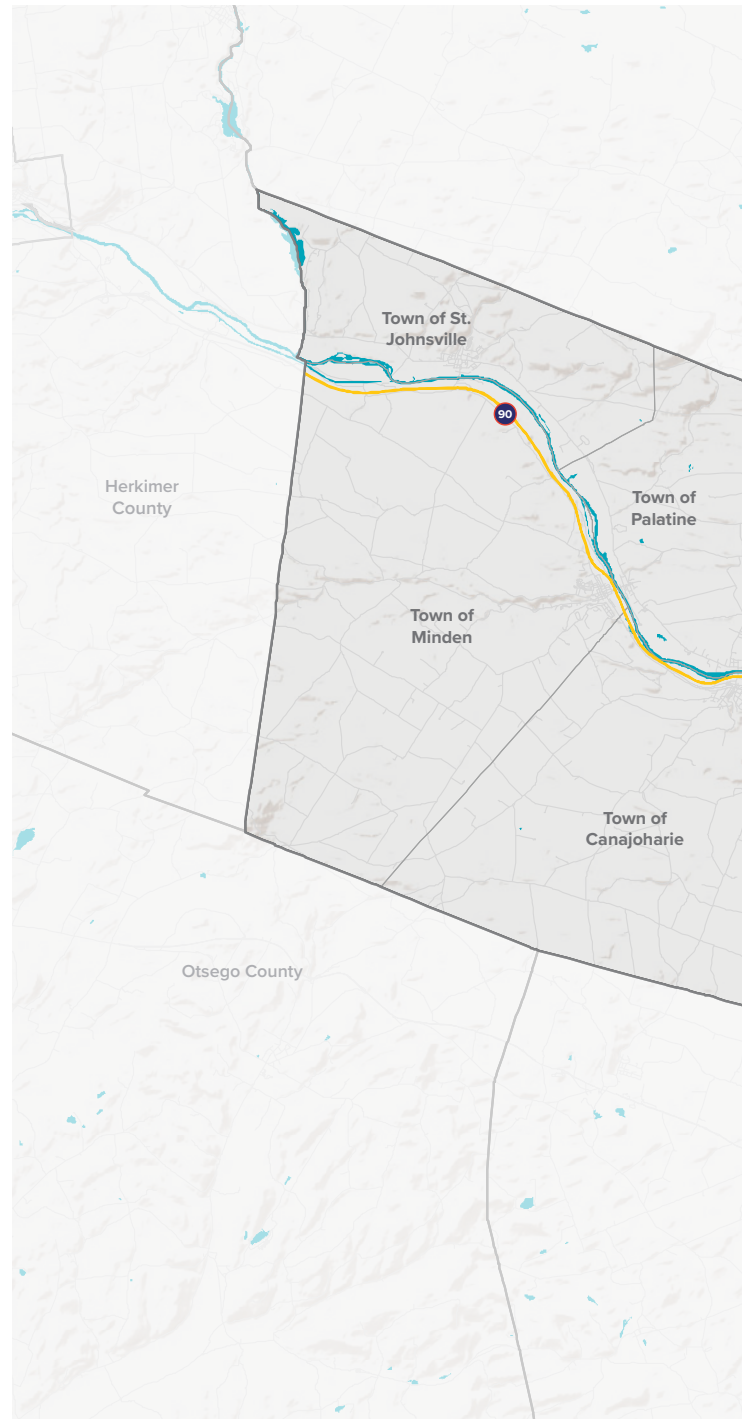
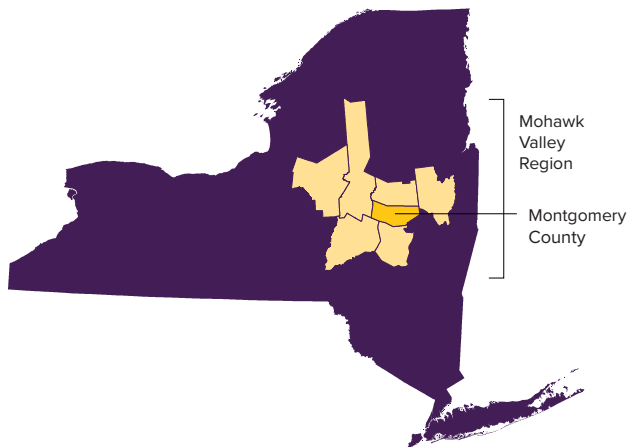
COMMUNITY PROFILE

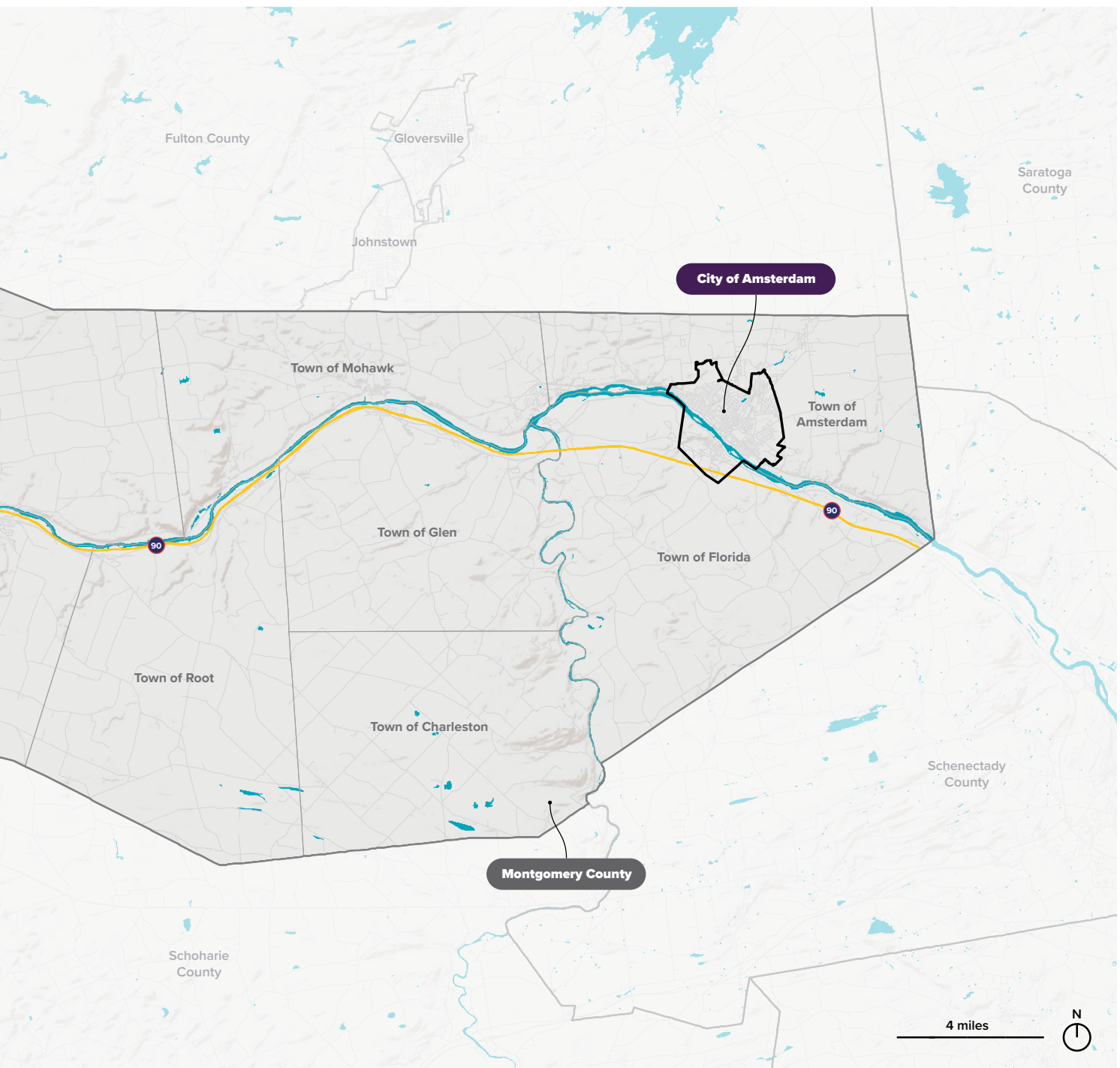
Our Location

The City of Amsterdam was shaped by its strategic location and unique geography.

Amsterdam is located in the Mohawk Valley region of New York State. In the early days, the valley's steep hills, powerful rivers, and fertile soil attracted indigenous communities and European settlers to the area. In time, the region became an agricultural center and was a strategic location during the American Revolution. The settlement that would become the City of Amsterdam developed by harnessing the power of the Mohawk River and Erie Canal for industry and trade.

Today, the City of Amsterdam is the largest population center and only city in Montgomery County – one of the seven counties in the Mohawk Valley Region. The city is bordered by the Town of Amsterdam to the north, east, and west and the Town of Florida to the south.





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Our History



Drawing of early Mohawk Valley community. Date unknown.



Market Street, Amsterdam. Circa 1905.

1700s

Amsterdam grows slowly.

Before the land that would become Amsterdam was settled by Europeans, it was inhabited for centuries by the Mohawk tribe of the Iroquois Confederacy. Dutch settlers began to arrive in the region in the 1660s and they reached what is now Amsterdam circa 1710. In these early days, the community was called Veedersburg after Albert Veeder, an early mill owner. By the next decade, waves of Scotch-Irish and German Palatine immigrants began to arrive in the Mohawk Valley region, but few settled in Amsterdam. After the Revolutionary War, Veedersburg grew very slowly, with a handful of mills, shops, and stores to support the needs of nearby farming communities. In 1804, the Town of Amsterdam was created and Veedersburg changed its name to Amsterdam.

1800s

Amsterdam rapidly expands.

The first half of the 19th-century brought rapid growth to Amsterdam. In 1830, Amsterdam was incorporated as a village and a new wave of immigrants from New England arrived. The completion of the Mohawk Turnpike in 1800, the Erie Canal in 1825, and the arrival of the railroad in 1836 improved trade and stimulated development. Soon, mills lined the Chuctanunda Creek and Amsterdam established itself as a manufacturing center for goods like brooms, knit ware, buttons, linseed oil, iron products and, most notably, carpets. At the time, Amsterdam was a destination for Irish, Italian, Polish, and Lithuanian immigrants who found work in the factories. In 1885, Amsterdam incorporated as a city and expanded by annexing several neighboring communities.



Main Street, Amsterdam. 1950s.



Main Street, Amsterdam. 2023.

1900s

Amsterdam slowly declines.

During the Great Depression, Amsterdam's factories slowed their output but did not close. The city also survived the two world wars without significant effect. However, shortly after World War II, factories in Amsterdam followed the general trend in the United States at the time and moved production to the South, where labor costs and taxes were lower. With limited jobs and opportunities available, younger generations went off to college and did not return. Amsterdam's population and tax base declined. In an attempt to draw people and business back to Amsterdam, the City and the State began a program of urban renewal and arterial roadway construction. This, however, served only to destroy much of the original fabric of downtown and had limited success in re-creating the city's industrial base.

21st Century

Amsterdam is experiencing a revival.

Like many post-industrial cities, Amsterdam is working to reinvent itself. In recent years, the city has seen significant investment, including \$10 million from New York State's Downtown Revitalization Initiative (DRI), which will fund a number of projects including extending the Chuctanunda Creek Trail, constructing a community center, and establishing a downtown improvement fund. Additional investment is going toward remediating and revitalizing brownfields across the city, including in the East End, Northern Neighborhoods, and along the waterfront. In 2023, the City updated its Local Waterfront Revitalization Program (LWRP) with new recommendations for enhancing waterfront connectivity, promoting waterfront redevelopment, and improving resiliency.

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Our People

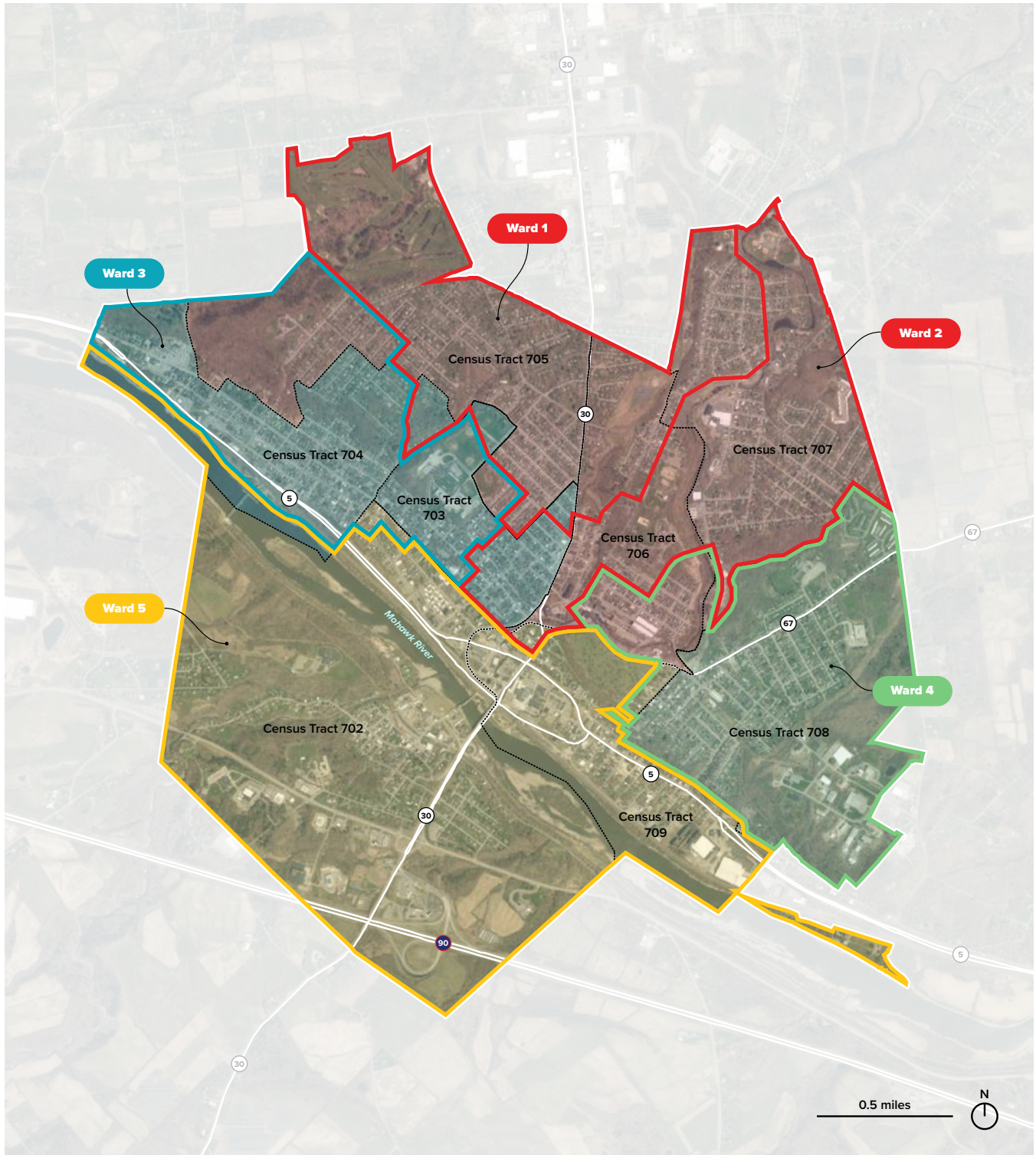
Amsterdam’s residents are an important piece of our community.

This section summarizes the City of Amsterdam’s residents, including who they are, where they live, and what they do for work. Understanding these facts about our community and how they have changed will help us make better decisions about Amsterdam’s future.

	Wards 1 & 2	Ward 3	Ward 4	Ward 5	Amsterdam	County
Census Tracts	705, 706, 707	703, 704	708	702, 709	702-709	N/A
Population	7,411	4,360	3,027	3,420	18,218	49,539
Size	2.1 mi ²	0.8 mi ²	0.9 mi ²	2.4 mi ²	6.3 mi ²	410 mi ²
^{Median} Household Income	\$48,597	\$44,663	\$37,083	\$32,322	\$43,164	\$53,533
Median Age	40.5 yrs	38.2 yrs	32.7 yrs	42.4 yrs	38.3 yrs	40.5 yrs
^{Non-Hispanic} White Population	70%	56%	52%	54%	60%	77%
Black Population	4%	2%	9%	12%	6%	2%
Hispanic or Latino	25%	35%	36%	33%	31%	15%
Vacancy Rate	16%	22%	22%	25%	21%	18%
Ownership Rate	63%	51%	36%	42%	52%	70%
Renter Rate	37%	49%	64%	58%	48%	30%
Pre-1940 Housing	46%	73%	48%	54%	55%	47%
Post-2000 Housing	0%	1%	4%	0%	1%	7%
Single-family Units	58%	31%	26%	26%	40%	59%
Duplexes	32%	48%	49%	46%	41%	21%

All data from American Community Survey (ACS) 2021 5-year estimates.

Wards Map



COMMUNITY PROFILE

Wards 1 and 2



Key Findings

Wards 1 and 2 exhibit strong neighborhood stability, with high homeownership rates, low vacancy, and high household incomes.

Median Household Income

Median household income is highest in Wards 1 and 2, averaging \$48,597. This is higher than the median income in Amsterdam (\$43,164), but lower than that in Montgomery County (\$53,533).

Neighborhood Stability

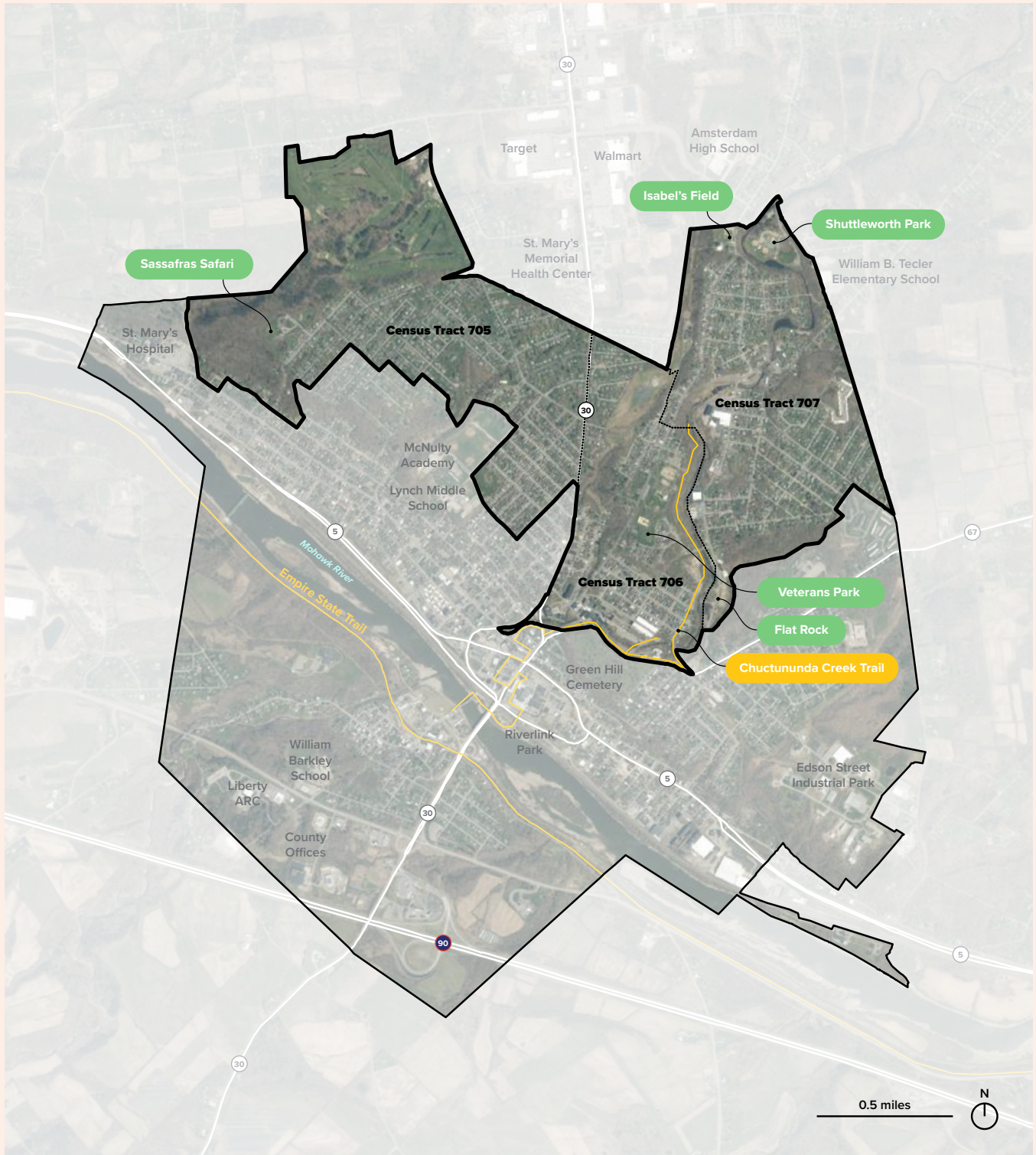
Wards 1 and 2 have the highest rate of owner-occupied housing (63%) in the city and the lowest vacancy rate (21%). In general, people that own their homes tend to stay in neighborhoods longer than renters, contributing to a stronger sense of stability and community.

Single-Family Neighborhoods

58% of housing units in Wards 1 and 2 are single-family units. Because of this, lots in Wards 1 and 2 are generally larger than lots in the other wards.

	Wards 1 & 2	Amsterdam
Population	7,411	18,218
Size	2.1 mi ²	6.3 mi ²
Median Household Income	\$48,597	\$43,164
Population under 25	32%	33%
Population over 65	16%	18%
Median Age	40.5 yrs	38.3 yrs
Non-Hispanic White Population	70%	60%
Black Population	4%	6%
Asian Population	1%	2%
Hispanic or Latino	25%	31%
Vacancy Rate	16%	21%
Ownership Rate	63%	52%
Renter Rate	37%	48%
Pre-1940 Housing	46%	55%
Post-2000 Housing	0%	1%
Single-family Units	58%	40%
Duplexes	32%	41%
Multi-Family Units	10%	19%

Wards 1 and 2 Map



COMMUNITY PROFILE

Ward 3



Key Findings

Ward 3 is dense and diverse, but has the oldest housing stock in the city.

Population Density

Ward 3 has the most people and the most housing units located in the smallest land area, making it the densest ward in the city. There are many duplexes and multi-family units in this ward and the lot sizes are generally smaller, which contribute to the denser neighborhood feel.

Diverse Population

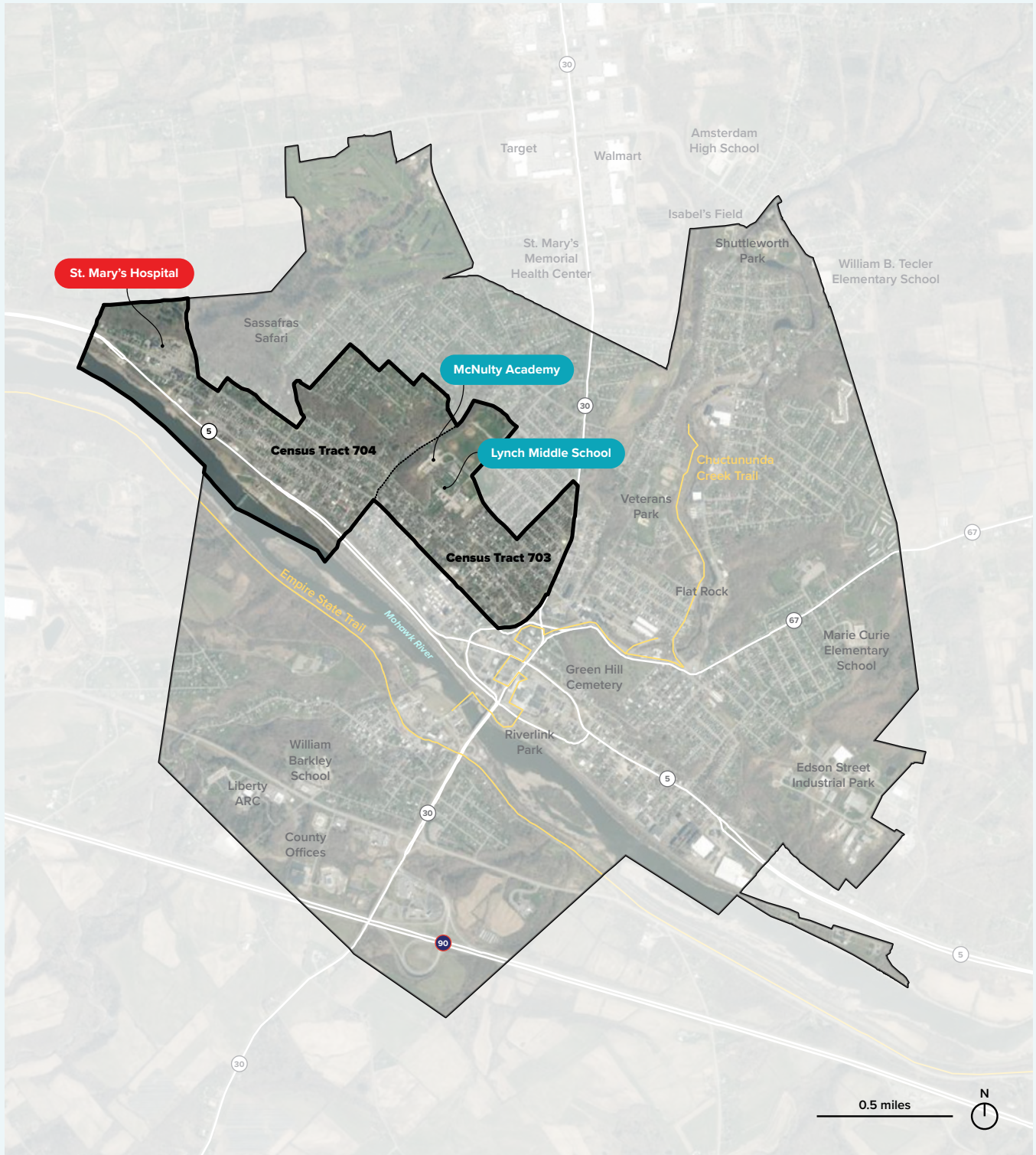
6% of Ward 3’s population identifies as Asian, a greater percentage than any other ward. In addition to this strong Asian community, there is also a strong Hispanic community with 35% of Ward 3 residents identifying as Hispanic or Latino.

Aging Housing Stock

Ward 3 has the largest percentage (73%) of its housing stock built before 1940, making the housing stock in Ward 3 the oldest in the city. The next oldest ward is Ward 5, where only 54% of housing units were built before 1940. Older housing units often require more repair and maintenance for upkeep.

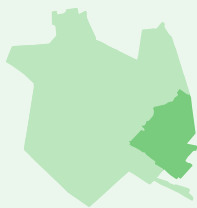
	Ward 3	Amsterdam
Population	4,360	18,218
Size	0.8 mi ²	6.3 mi ²
Median Household Income	\$44,663	\$43,164
Population under 25	33%	33%
Population over 65	16%	18%
Median Age	38.2 yrs	38.3 yrs
Non-Hispanic White Population	56%	60%
Black Population	2%	6%
Asian Population	6%	2%
Hispanic or Latino	35%	31%
Vacancy Rate	22%	21%
Ownership Rate	51%	52%
Renter Rate	49%	48%
Pre-1940 Housing	73%	55%
Post-2000 Housing	1%	1%
Single-family Units	31%	40%
Duplexes	48%	41%
Multi-Family Units	21%	19%

Ward 3 Map



COMMUNITY PROFILE

Ward 4



Key Findings

Ward 4 has a young, diverse population, with a lot of renters.

Young and Diverse Population

Ward 4 has the largest percentage of its population under the age of 25 (37%) and the median age in Ward 4 (32.7 years) is 5.5 years younger than any other ward. A younger population requires unique services like daycares and playgrounds.

Ward 4 also has the most diverse population of all wards, with almost half of residents identifying as non-white including 36% as Hispanic or Latino and 9% as black.

Mostly Renters

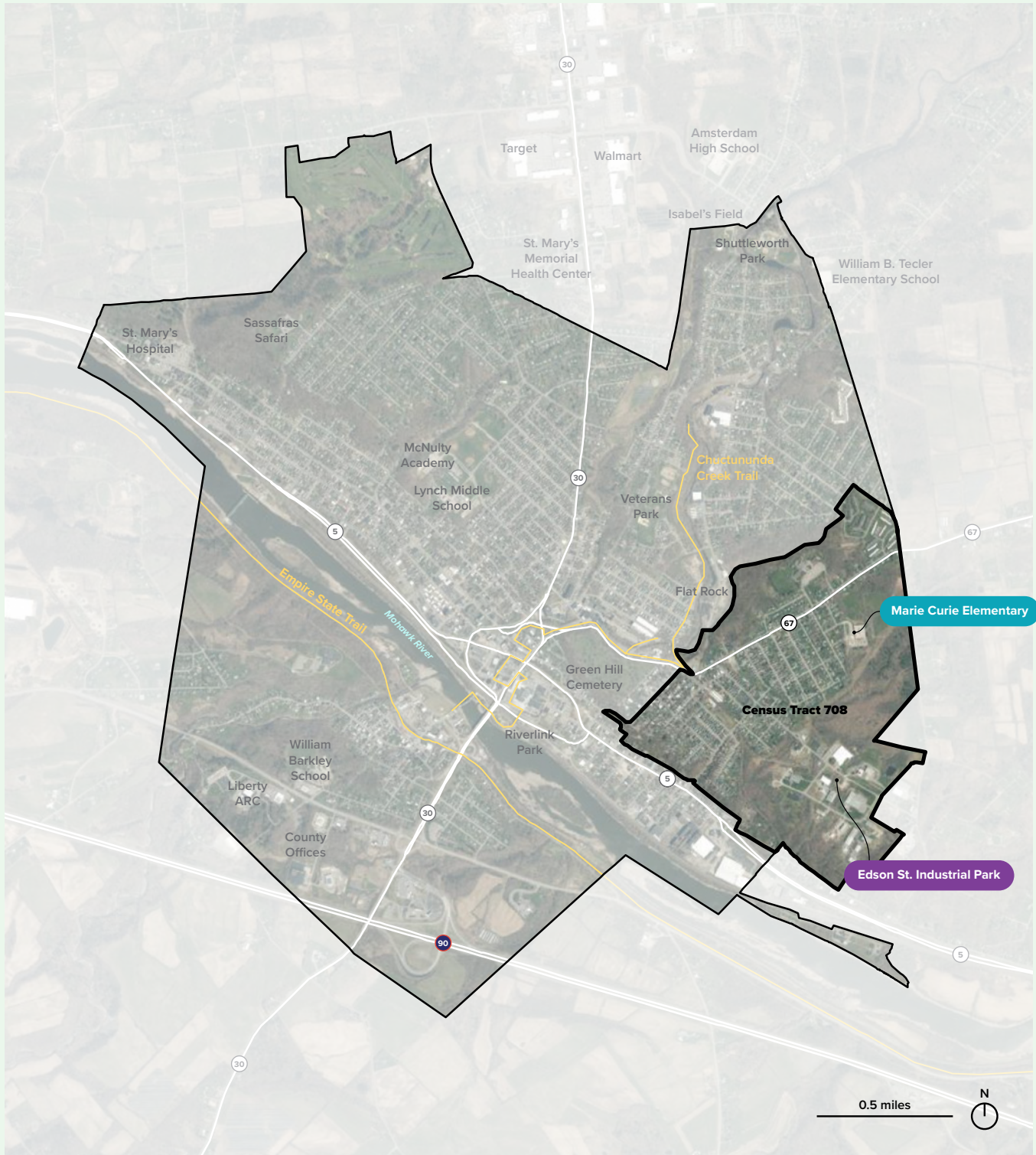
64% of housing units in Ward 4 are occupied by renters, the highest of all wards. Neighborhoods with more renters often have more turnover than neighborhoods with more owners.

Some New Housing Construction

Ward 4 is one of the only wards seeing new construction, with 4% of housing units being built since 2000.

	Ward 4	Amsterdam
Population	3,027	18,218
Size	0.9 mi ²	6.3 mi ²
Median Household Income	\$37,083	\$43,164
Population under 25	37%	33%
Population over 65	12%	18%
Median Age	32.7 yrs	38.3 yrs
Non-Hispanic White Population	52%	60%
Black Population	9%	6%
Asian Population	0%	2%
Hispanic or Latino	36%	31%
Vacancy Rate	22%	21%
Ownership Rate	36%	52%
Renter Rate	64%	48%
Pre-1940 Housing	48%	55%
Post-2000 Housing	4%	1%
Single-family Units	26%	40%
Duplexes	49%	41%
Multi-Family Units	25%	19%

Ward 4 Map



COMMUNITY PROFILE

Ward 5



Key Findings

Ward 5 has some of the most varied housing options in the city, but struggles with high vacancy and low household incomes.

Median Household Income

Ward 5 has the lowest median income of the wards, averaging \$32,322. This is notably lower than the city's median income which is \$43,164.

Aging Population

Ward 5 has the largest percentage of its population over the age of 65 (28%). Its median age is 42.4 years, the oldest of the wards.

High Vacancy Rate

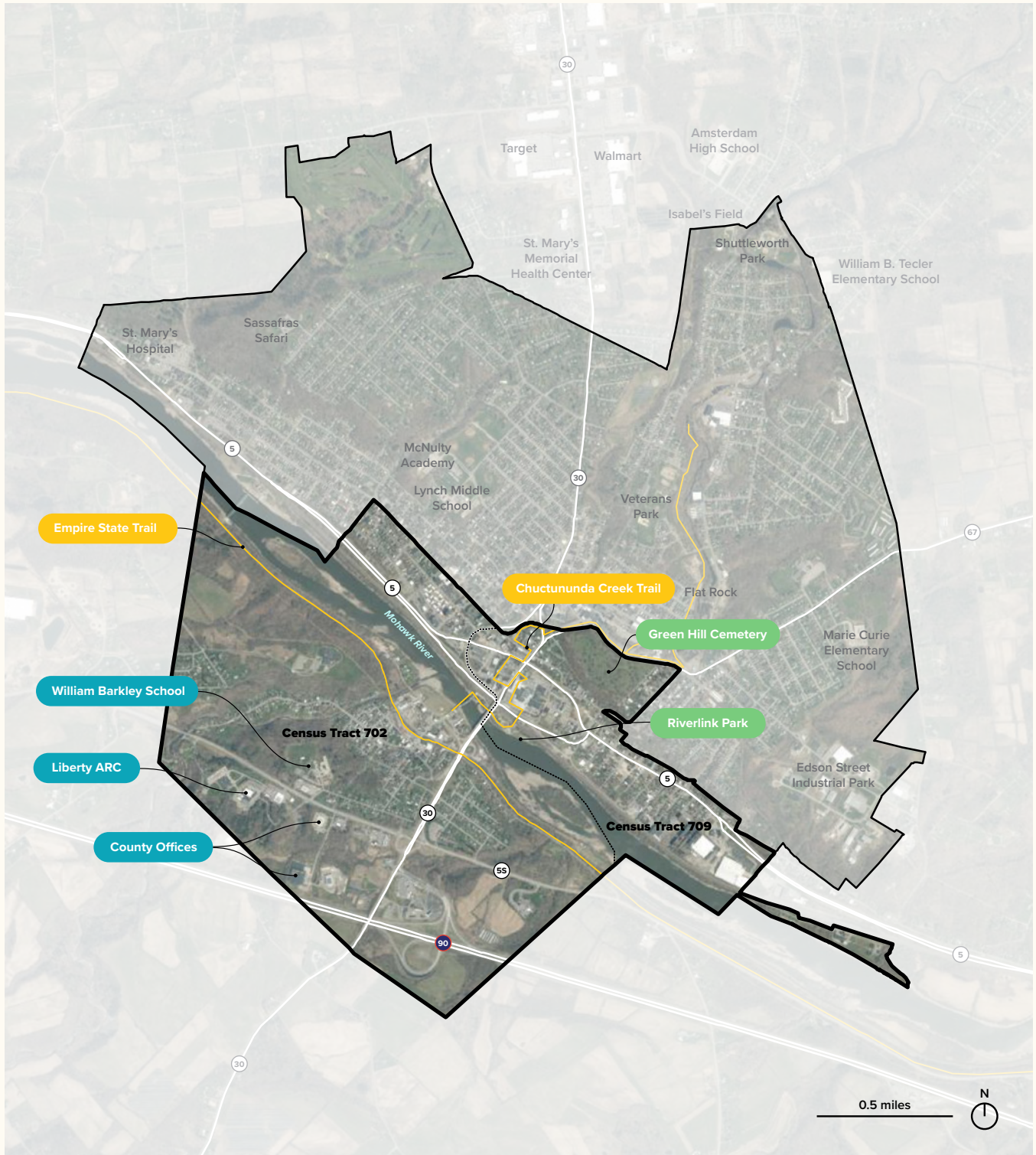
The vacancy rate for housing units in Ward 5 is 25%, higher than any other ward. Vacant housing units can negatively impact communities and contribute to blight.

Varied Housing Stock

Ward 5's housing stock has the largest percentage of multi-family units. 29% of housing units in Ward 5 have 3 or more units, including 10% of units with 20 or more units.

	Ward 5	Amsterdam
Population	3,420	18,218
Size	2.4 mi ²	6.3 mi ²
Median Household Income	\$32,322	\$43,164
Population under 25	28%	33%
Population over 65	28%	18%
Median Age	42.4 yrs	38.3 yrs
Non-Hispanic White Population	54%	60%
Black Population	12%	6%
Asian Population	0%	2%
Hispanic or Latino	33%	31%
Vacancy Rate	25%	21%
Ownership Rate	42%	52%
Renter Rate	58%	48%
Pre-1940 Housing	54%	55%
Post-2000 Housing	0%	1%
Single-family Units	26%	40%
Duplexes	46%	41%
Multi-Family Units	29%	19%

Ward 5 Map



COMMUNITY PROFILE

Key Findings

The following pages highlight several key findings about Amsterdam that should be considered as the city plans for the future.

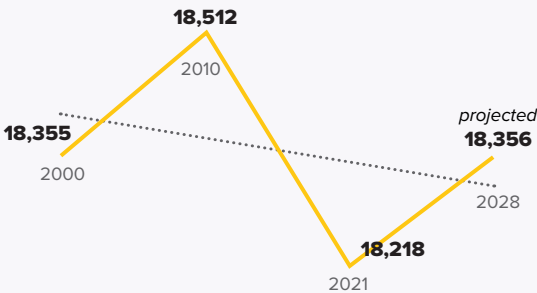
01

Amsterdam is projected to grow.

More people are expected to live in Amsterdam by 2030.

Amsterdam’s current population is 18,218. By 2028, Amsterdam’s population is projected to increase by 1% to 18,356, reversing the declining trend in population from 2010 to 2021. Amsterdam’s projected growth is consistent with projected trends in the Town of Amsterdam and Montgomery County as well.

A growing population can be a boon for economic growth and cultural diversity. More people also require more services, housing, and job availability.



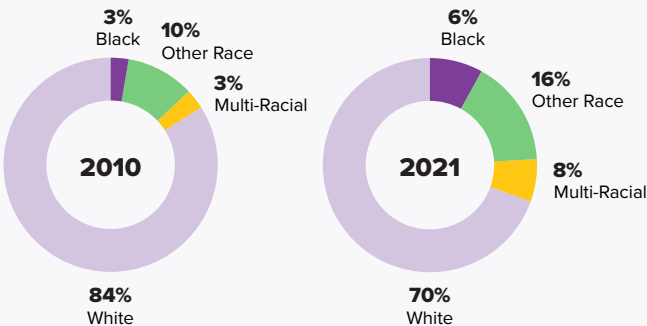
02

Amsterdam is becoming more diverse.

Amsterdam is experiencing increasing racial and ethnic diversity.

In the last decade, Amsterdam’s population has become more diverse. In 2021, 30% of residents identified as non-white, up from 16% in 2010. A total of 6% of residents identified as black, 16% as some other race, and 8% as multi-racial. The city also has a strong Hispanic community, accounting for 31% of residents. This is twice the rate of Hispanic residents in Montgomery County (15%).

A diverse population contributes to cultural richness and economic diversity, leading to positive social impacts.



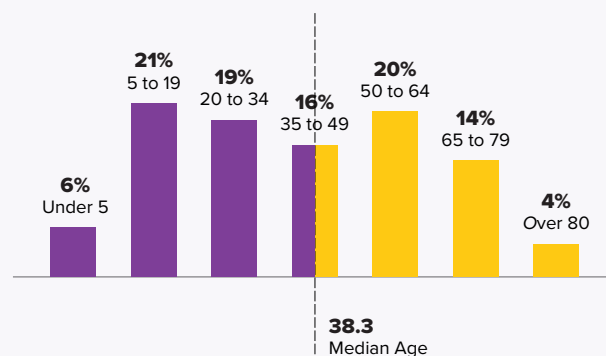
03

Amsterdam has a balanced age distribution.

Population is split among the age ranges.

With the exception of the very young and the very old, Amsterdam's population is split relatively evenly among the age ranges. This type of age distribution is indicative of a balanced population, where birth and death rates and immigration and emigration are equal.

For a balanced population, it is important to provide a range of services and housing options that can meet the needs of all residents.



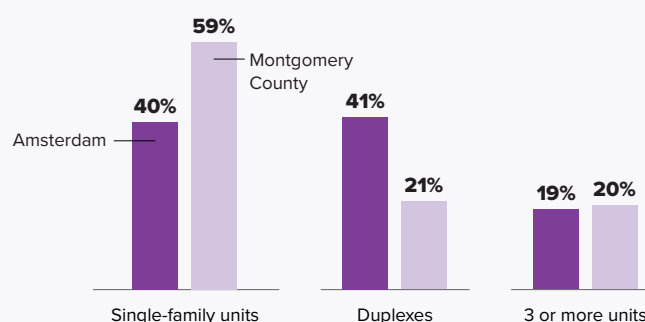
04

Amsterdam has various housing options.

Two-family units are the most common housing type.

The largest segment of Amsterdam's housing stock is duplexes (41%), followed by single-family units (40%), and units with 3 or more units (19%). This is in contrast to Montgomery County, where single-family units are the majority (59%).

A diversity of available housing type options makes Amsterdam attractive to a broader range of potential residents.



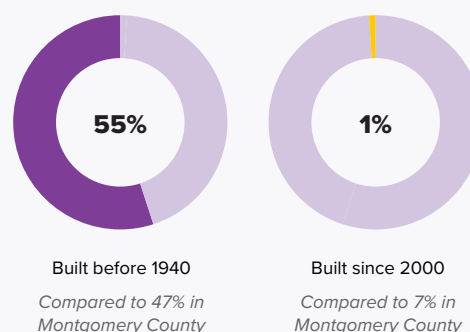
05

The housing stock is old.

Most homes in Amsterdam were built before 1940.

More than half of the city's housing stock is at least 80 years old or older, with 55% of housing units being built before 1940. Less than 1% of the city's housing stock was built since 2000.

An older housing stock can bring character to a community but also brings challenges like the need for more upkeep. Older housing can also be less desirable for certain populations, like young people or those requiring handicap accessibility.



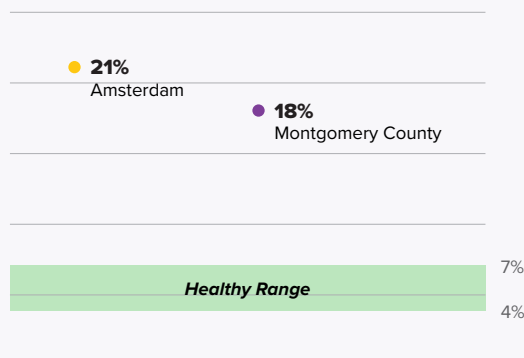
06

Residential vacancy is high.

Many housing units sit unused.

Amsterdam's vacancy rate is 21%, greater than the 18% rate in Montgomery County, and well above the ideal vacancy rate of 4% to 7%.

High vacancy rates often indicate a mismatch in the market, where housing unit types or price points do not match consumers' needs.



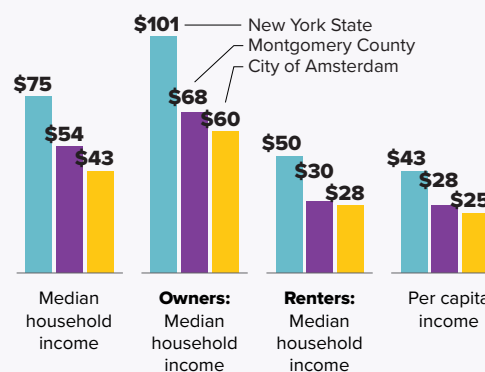
07

Household incomes are low.

Especially for renters.

Household incomes are lower in Amsterdam than in Montgomery County and New York State. Median household income for renters in the city (\$28,000) is less than half of that for homeowners (\$60,000).

Low incomes mean households spend a greater percentage of their income on housing costs and have less to spend on other goods and services in the local economy.



Income shown in thousands of dollars.

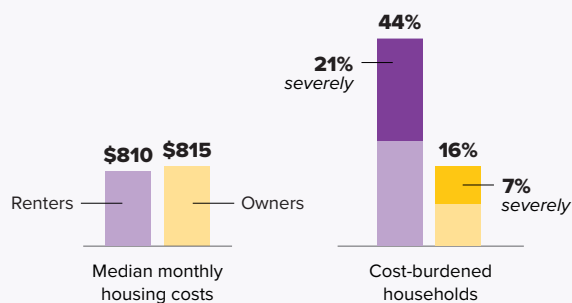
08

Families cannot afford their housing costs.

Many families are considered cost-burdened.

44% of renters in the city are considered "cost-burdened," meaning that they spend more than 30% of their household income on rent. Almost half of these renters (21%) are severely cost-burdened, spending more than 50% of their income on rent. In addition, 16% of homeowners are cost-burdened, 7% severely.

The considerable amount of cost-burdened families in Amsterdam suggests that housing costs are not affordable for many, especially renters. A wider range of price points, particularly lower rents, can help meet the needs of all income ranges.



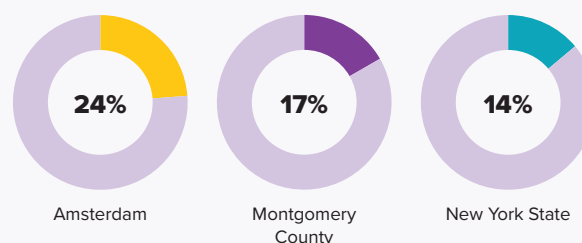
09

The poverty rate is high.

Many families in Amsterdam are struggling to make ends meet.

Amsterdam's poverty rate is 24%, compared to 17% in Montgomery County and 14% in New York.

Poverty is an enduring issue that affects quality of life and limits opportunities for families. Expanded access to jobs, housing, and education can uplift communities and end the cycle of poverty.



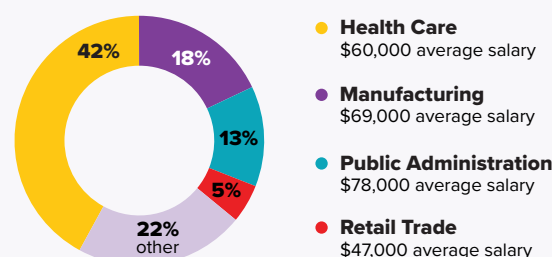
10

Good jobs are available in Amsterdam.

The top industry sectors in Amsterdam offer good paying jobs.

The top industry sectors in Amsterdam are health care (42% of available jobs), manufacturing (18%), public administration (13%), and retail trade (5%). These industries generally offer good paying jobs, with average salaries above \$55,000.

Quality job opportunities are an important piece of a vibrant economy. They help workers provide for their families, encourage spending, and also help the city attract new residents.



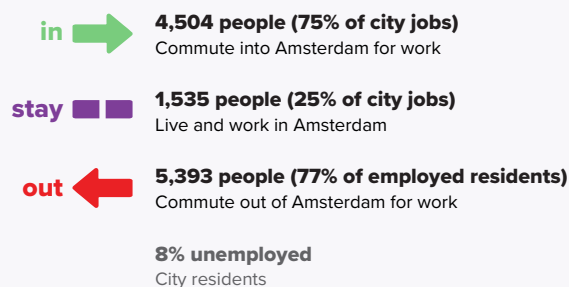
11

Access to jobs is an issue.

Many residents commute out of the city for work.

While good jobs are available in Amsterdam, only 25% of jobs located in the city are going to city residents. 77% of residents are commuting outside the city for work. On top of that, more than 8% of city residents are unemployed, compared to a healthy rate of 3% to 5%.

A large commuter population, despite good jobs in the city, may indicate a mismatch between residents' skills and job requirements. Workforce training programs could help bridge this gap.

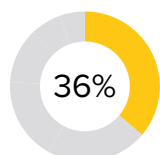


COMMUNITY PROFILE

Our Places

Amsterdam is characterized by a diverse mix of land uses, from residential and commercial properties to recreation spaces and vacant lands.

Residential

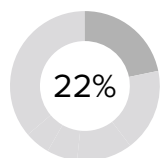


Residential land is the most prominent use within the City of Amsterdam (accounting for over 1,100 acres and 36% of total city land use). Residential areas are distributed throughout the city, with concentrations in the West End, Northern Neighborhoods, and the northern and eastern portion of the East End. Additional residential land uses are located south of the Mohawk River in the South End, near downtown.

Single-family housing makes up most of the residential land use (64.2%), with two-family housing being the second highest form of housing (25.9%). Apartments, three-family units and multi-family residences round out the remaining housing totaling 9.9%.

Key Finding: Future development could focus on expanding mixed-income housing options, particularly in neighborhoods with significant vacant land, to promote inclusive housing opportunities.

Vacant Land

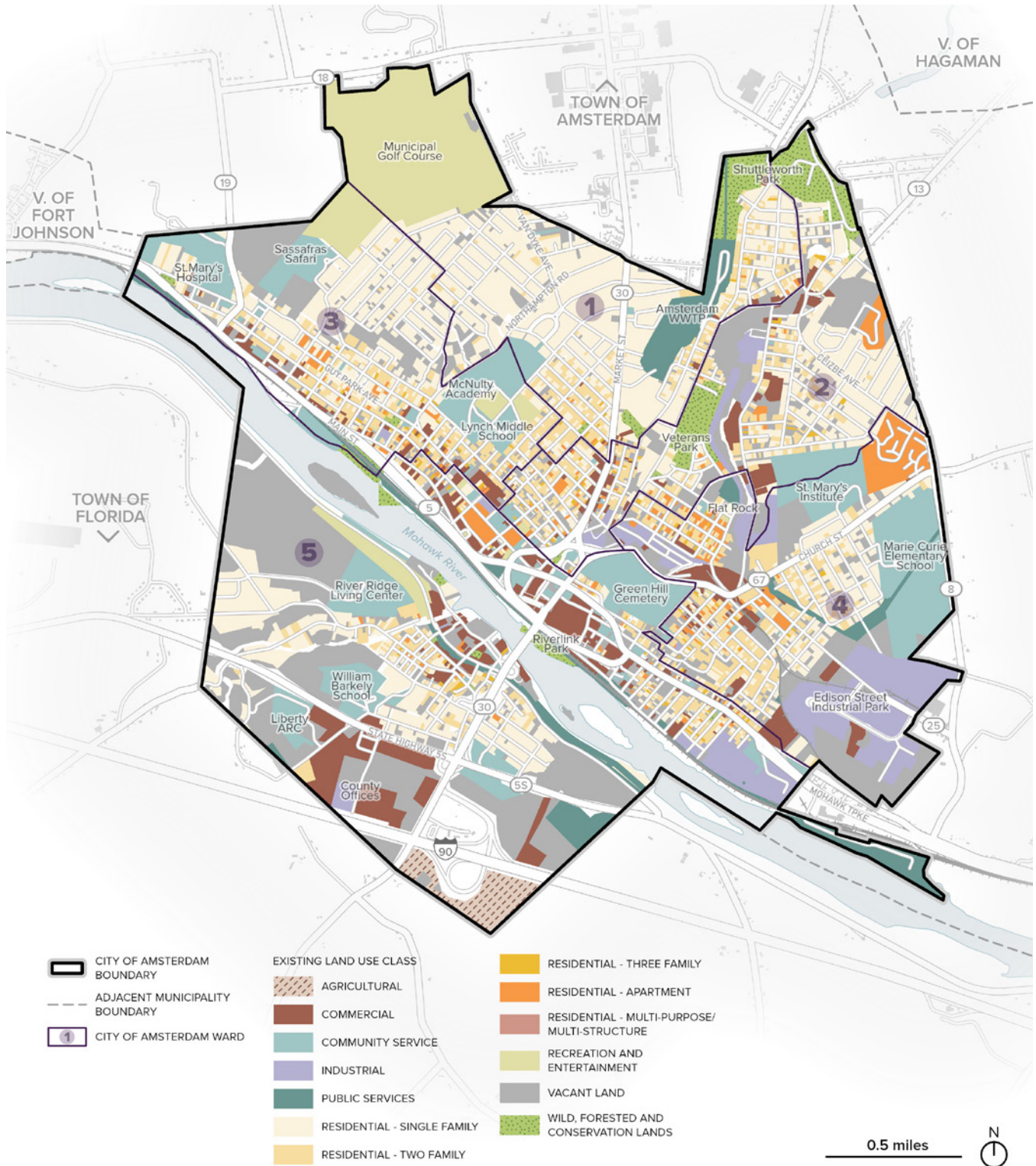


Vacant land accounts for 22% of Amsterdam's total land use, representing a significant opportunity for infill development and revitalization. Vacant commercial and residential parcels are interspersed throughout the city neighborhoods and downtown area but the largest vacant parcels are south of the Mohawk River.

Other areas of the city with concentrated vacant land include a number of vacant properties identified in the City of Amsterdam's Northern Neighborhoods and East End BOA studies. The East End BOA identified 29 acres, and more than 46 sites as being either brownfields, vacant, or underutilized. The Northern Neighborhoods BOA identified 40 sites as potential brownfields, vacant, or underutilized properties.

Key Finding: Appropriately sized vacant and underutilized areas may provide infill opportunities that revitalize neighborhoods and enhance the local economy.

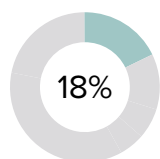
Existing Land Use Map





Commercial uses on Main Street.

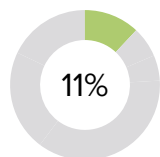
Public and Community Services



Amsterdam's public and community services make up 18% of total city land use combined. Community services play a critical role in supporting community health, education, and well-being and include things like schools, hospitals, and nursing homes. Public services are designed to support the general public and include things like the Amsterdam Wastewater Treatment Plant.

Key Finding: As Amsterdam grows, expanding services and ensuring equitable access to these resources, particularly in underserved neighborhoods, will be essential.

Recreation



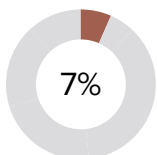
Parcels classified as recreation, public parks, conservation areas, or agricultural lands make up 11% of Amsterdam's total land use. Notable areas include the 182-acre Amsterdam Municipal Golf Course and Shuttleworth Park, which serve as key recreational hubs.

Key Finding: In alignment with Smart Growth principles, Amsterdam should continue to protect and expand these green spaces, ensuring all residents have access to parks and natural areas.



Industrial uses on Church Street.

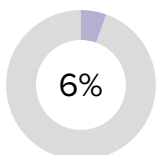
Commercial



Amsterdam has 7% of its existing land use dedicated to commercial uses. Commercial uses are primarily located near Amsterdam's downtown corridors, including Washington, Church, Liberty, East and West Main, Front and Market Streets, among others. The city's commercial land use is diverse and includes a variety of shops, restaurants, banks, and offices, which provide local job opportunities and goods and services for residents.

Key Finding: Future commercial development should focus on revitalizing existing structures and enhancing downtown areas with mixed-use projects.

Industrial



Industrial land uses, make up about 6% of the city's land use. Industrial uses are primarily concentrated in the East End of the city, with a number of industrial properties in the Northern Neighborhoods as well, particularly along Chuctanunda Creek.

Key Finding: Industrial redevelopment efforts should focus on transitioning underutilized properties into innovative spaces that support job creation and emerging industries.

COMMUNITY PROFILE

Zoning

Amsterdam's Zoning Code guides development patterns in the city by establishing standards for land use, building dimensions, and occupancy.

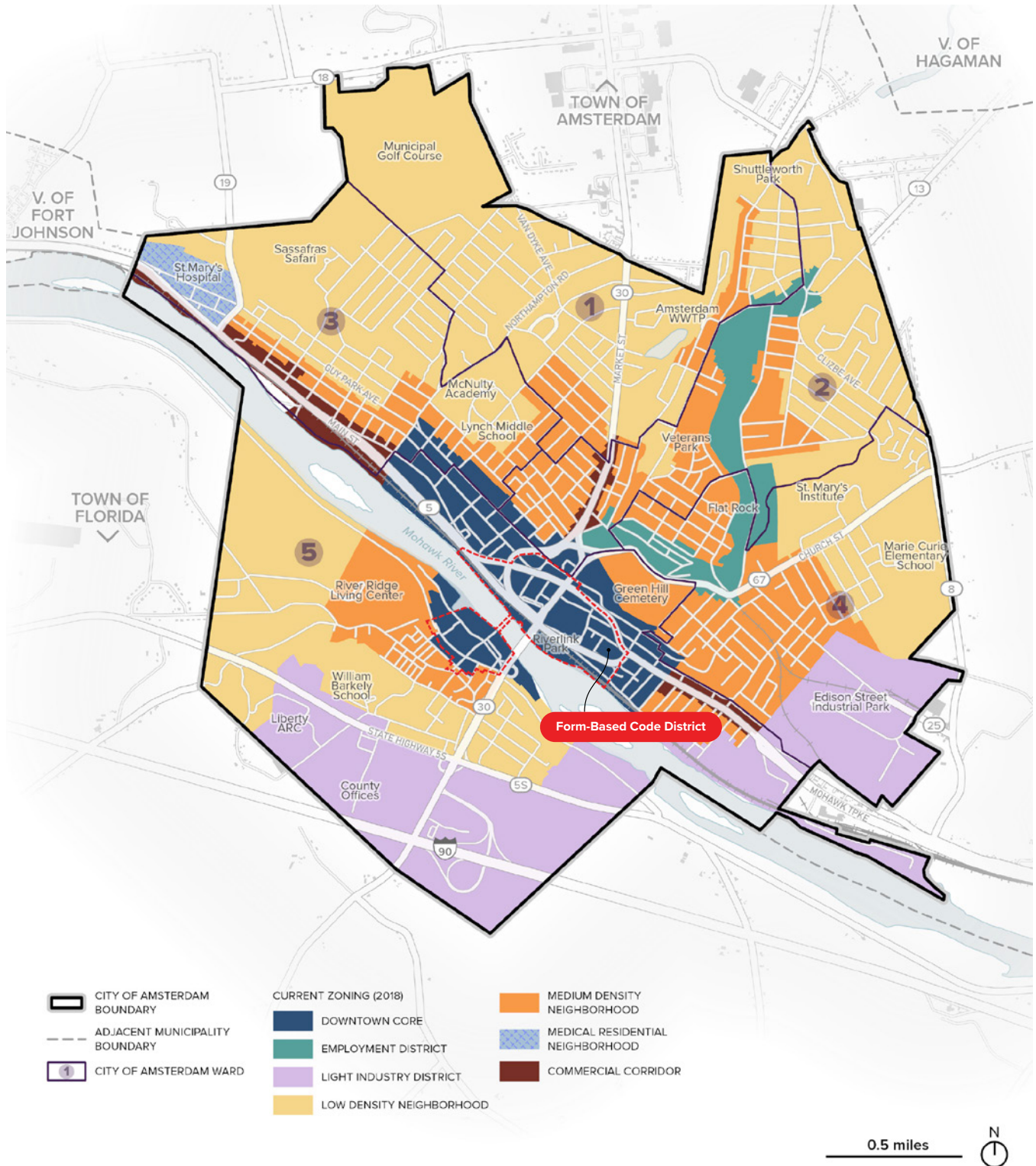
Zoning Districts

The city's approach to zoning follows a clear and logical density model, promoting higher-density development near the downtown core while encouraging lower densities in outer neighborhoods. This approach helps to concentrate growth in areas with existing infrastructure and amenities.

The City of Amsterdam has seven zoning districts:

-  **Low Density Neighborhood:** This district is designed to support single-family detached residences along with complementary community uses, such as gardens, parks, and playgrounds, fostering a strong sense of community and a pedestrian-friendly environment.
-  **Medium Density Neighborhood:** This district is designed to promote a diverse range of residential types while maintaining an appropriate scale and variety of densities. It allows for higher density development compared to the outer portions of the city, supporting a more compact and urban residential environment.
-  **Medical Residential Neighborhood:** This district aims to balance the preservation of existing residential neighborhoods with the needs of nearby medical facilities by protecting residential character from the potential negative impacts of hospital expansions while still allowing for the continued operation, redevelopment, and expansion of medical facilities as needed.
-  **Downtown Core:** This district is intended to accommodate a wide variety of uses in the central business district of the city while optimizing development opportunities for mixed-uses, residential dwellings, pedestrian-oriented circulation, entertainment, and urban activity.
-  **Employment District:** This district is designed to support a mix of residential, public, and employment-generating uses, including commercial and research development. The primary goal of this district is to expand employment opportunities by accommodating businesses in diverse locations, offering services for employees near their workplaces, and providing integrated living, working, and shopping environments.
-  **Commercial Corridor:** This district is strategically designed to accommodate a variety of commercial uses, including retail, personal services, and entertainment businesses, along the city's major vehicular corridors. By concentrating commercial activity along these key corridors, this district supports Amsterdam's economic vitality and appeal to a broader regional audience.
-  **Light Industry District:** This district provides land for uses associated with manufacturing, warehousing, storage, and other intensive uses.

Zoning Districts Map



Overlay Zones

Amsterdam's Zoning Code also incorporates three overlay zones that create additional regulations on top of the underlying zoning district for special purposes such as protecting sensitive environmental features or preserving historic character. Amsterdam's overlay zones include:

- **Greenway Corridor Overlay Zone:** The Greenway Corridor Overlay Zone was an outgrowth of the 2003 Comprehensive Plan, which recommended creating a city greenway system to protect riparian corridors and provide recreation opportunities. As stated in the Zoning Code, the purpose of this overlay zone is to protect public health, safety and welfare from the effects of flooding, protect against erosion by enhancing and protecting riparian buffers, provide habitat for plants and wildlife, and preserve and protect specific areas for passive recreation, such as trails, overlooks, parks, and nature sanctuaries.
- **Historic Resources Overlay Zone:** Amsterdam has many significant historic, architectural, and cultural resources and the intent of the Historic Resources Overlay Zone is to protect these resources, foster civic pride in the accomplishments of the past, protect and enhance the city of Amsterdam's attractiveness to visitors, and ensure the harmonious, orderly, and efficient growth and development of the city.
- **Gateway Overlay Zone:** The Gateway Overlay Zone was created in response to the 2003 Comprehensive Plan which recommended enhancing important transportation corridors and gateways into the city by improving their function and appearance. The intent of this overlay zone is to improve the appearance of major entry roadways into the city by requiring special consideration for design and aesthetic improvements during site plan review and by enhancing multi-modal accessibility of the gateway corridors through improved pedestrian, bike, and vehicular facilities.

Form-Based Code District

As an outgrowth of the Downtown Revitalization Initiative (DRI), the City of Amsterdam adopted a Form-Based Code District to guide development within the DRI boundary, which overlaps with a portion of the Downtown Core district. Upon adoption, the Form-Based Code superseded and replaced all existing zoning code provisions for the properties located within the DRI boundary, as well as lots immediately adjacent to the boundary in order to ensure appropriate transitions from downtown to the surrounding area.

The Form-Based Code regulates the physical form of the built environment in this district in order to improve the physical character and aesthetics of downtown, promote walkability and multi-modal access, protect historic resources where appropriate, and streamline permitting and approval processes for future development in downtown Amsterdam.

VISUAL DISTINCTION BETWEEN GROUND AND UPPER FLOORS

Building facade elements, such as large windows, changes in materials and colors, awnings, and window signs, help distinguish ground floors from the upper floors and reinforce a pedestrian-scale streetscape.



City of Amsterdam | Form-Based Code | Section 4.1 - Buildings

Zoning Districts Table

Zoning District	Principal Permitted Uses	Dimensional Requirements
 Low Density Neighborhood	Single-family dwelling, community park or playground, community gardening.	MIN lot size: 8,500 square feet MIN lot width: 80 feet MIN front setback: 30 feet MAX building coverage: 30% MAX height of building: 40 feet
 Medium Density Neighborhood	Single-family dwelling, two-family dwelling.	MIN lot size: 5,000 square feet MIN lot width: 50 feet MIN front setback: 20 feet MAX building coverage: 35% MAX height of building: 40 feet
 Medical Residential Neighborhood	Single-family dwelling, two-family dwelling, conversion of existing residential structures to a medical use if no exterior change is made, hospitals, medical offices, and dental offices, nursing home, bed-and-breakfast.	MIN lot size: 5,000 square feet MIN lot width: 50 feet MIN front setback: 20 feet MAX building coverage: 40% MAX building height: 40 feet
 Downtown Core <i>*A portion of this district is regulated by the Form-Based Code</i>	Single-family dwelling, two-family dwelling, second-story residential, retail, restaurants and bars, offices, artist's studio, financial institutions, child care, medical clinics, motels and hotels, park or playground, condominiums. By Special Permit: Multi-family dwelling, auto sales, auto service station, smoke shops, cannabis retail.	MIN lot size: 5,000 square feet MIN lot width: 50 feet MIN front setback: 0 feet MAX front setback: 20 feet MAX building coverage: 60% MAX building height: 150 feet
 Employment District	*Same as Downtown Core District By Special Permit: Multi-family dwelling, auto sales, auto service station, smoke shops, cannabis retail, manufacture, and on-site consumption.	MIN lot size: 10,000 square feet MIN lot width: 80 feet MIN front setback: 30 feet MAX building coverage: 40% MAX building height: 40 feet
 Commercial Corridor	Single-family dwelling, second-story residential, retail, restaurants and bars, offices, artist's studio, financial institutions, child care, medical clinics, motels and hotels, park or playground, condominiums. By Special Permit: Multi-family dwelling, auto service station, smoke shops, cannabis retail, manufacture, and on-site consumption.	MIN lot size: 5,000 square feet MIN lot width: 50 feet MIN front setback: 10 feet MAX building coverage: 60% MAX building height: 70 feet
 Light Industry District	Alcoholic beverage production and sale facility, auto service station, contractor's storage yard, light manufacturing, commercial storage and retail warehouse, wholesale establishment, repair services, machine shop, equipment rentals, lumberyard, park or playground, funeral home.	MIN lot size: 30,000 square feet MIN lot width: 150 feet MIN front setback: 50 feet MAX building coverage: 30% MAX building height: 40 feet

COMMUNITY PROFILE

Transportation

Amsterdam's transportation network provides critical connections between neighborhoods, employment centers, schools, parks, and the broader region. The following section describes the city's roadway network, multimodal assets, transit services, parking supply, and emerging mobility options, as well as ongoing investments designed to strengthen connectivity.

Regional Connectivity

Amsterdam benefits from strong regional highway access. The New York State Thruway (I-90) runs along the southern portion of the city, with Interchange 27 providing direct access to Amsterdam south of NYS Route 5S. Regionally, I-90 connects the city east to Schenectady and Albany and west to Utica, Syracuse, and Western New York.

A primarily gridded street network supports local mobility. NYS Route 30 is the main north-south artery, connecting the South Side and downtown via the Mohawk River bridge. NYS Routes 5 and 67 serve as the primary east-west corridors. Route 5 (Front Street) parallels the railroad corridor and connects the West End, Downtown, and East End neighborhoods.

Within downtown, a segment of Route 5 functions as an elevated limited-access arterial. While this roadway provides efficient vehicular travel and access to Route 30 and I-90, its elevated structure also creates a barrier between downtown and the Mohawk River waterfront.

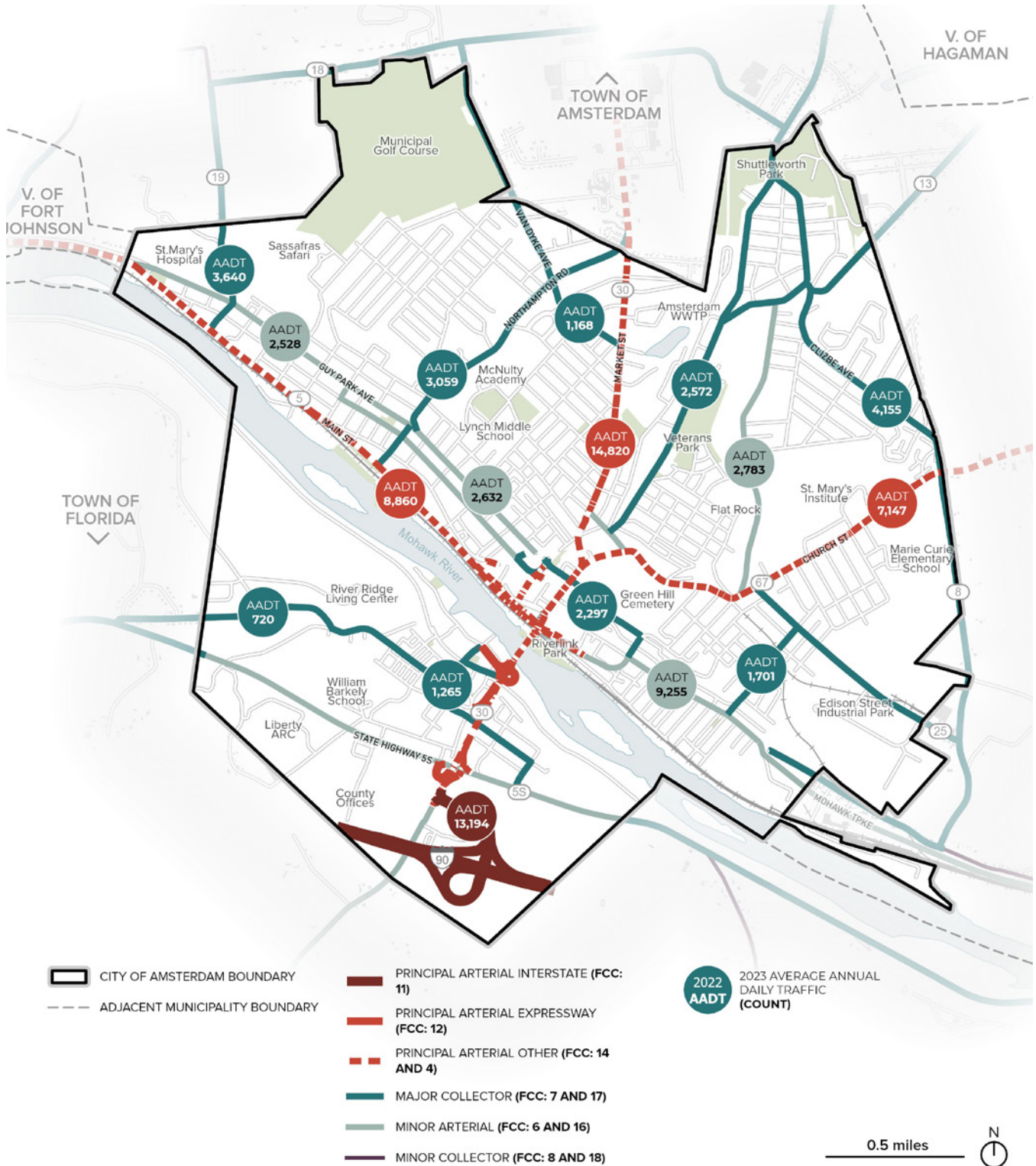
Roadway Network

Amsterdam's roadway system provides generally good motor vehicle access, with approximately 75 centerline miles and 147 lane miles of roadways (NYSDOT Local Highway Inventory). Traffic volumes are highest along Market Street (AADT 14,280), West Main Street (AADT 8,860), and near the I-90 interchange area (over 13,000 AADT).

The Mohawk River, part of the New York State Canal System, is also a key transportation and recreation asset. Lock 11 accommodates roughly 2,000 boats annually. Additionally, the Empire State Trail runs along the South Side and continues west through Montgomery County, offering long-distance recreation and nonmotorized travel opportunities.

Albany International Airport, the nearest major airport, is located approximately 35 minutes south of Amsterdam.

Transportation Systems Map



Ongoing and Planned Projects

Amsterdam is actively investing in transportation improvements that enhance safety, accessibility, and multimodal connectivity. The Downtown Gateway and Complete Streets initiatives aim to modernize Amsterdam's key commercial corridors with new sidewalks, updated lighting, landscaping, traffic-calming features, and enhanced pedestrian and bicycle accommodations. These efforts focus on East Main Street, Main Street downtown, and Bridge Street.

The Downtown Revitalization Initiative (DRI) also identifies several transportation-oriented projects, including extending the Chuctanunda Creek Trail, improving access to the MVGO Bridge, and reconfiguring a section of Route 5 within the DRI boundary to strengthen linkages between neighborhoods, downtown, and the waterfront. Together, these projects advance the city's goals for improved connectivity, walkability, and public realm enhancements.

Key Finding: Major investments—through DRI, Complete Streets, and gateway enhancements—are already transforming Amsterdam's transportation network and strengthening multimodal access.

Sidewalks & Pedestrian Access

Sidewalks connect Amsterdam's neighborhoods to downtown, schools, bus routes, parks, and waterfront destinations. While sidewalks are common in the downtown core and adjacent areas, many residential neighborhoods lack sidewalks or safe pedestrian crossings, particularly along busy corridors. These gaps restrict mobility for residents without reliable vehicle access and limit opportunities for walking and bicycling.

The Northern Neighborhoods BOA Nomination Study recommends a Transportation and Access Study focused on heavily traveled corridors and dense residential areas. The study would help establish complete streets standards and guide future transportation investments. A public engagement process is recommended to ensure that improvements reflect resident needs.

Key Finding: Sidewalk gaps limit safe and reliable pedestrian access, especially in neighborhoods with limited vehicle availability.

Sidewalks & Pedestrian Access

Public transportation in Amsterdam is provided by the Capital District Transportation Authority (CDTA). The network includes regular bus routes, express service, bus rapid transit connections, on-demand FLEX service, bike share (CDPHP Cycle!), electric car share (DRIVE), seasonal trolley service, park-and-ride lots, and STAR paratransit service for individuals with disabilities. Primary routes serving Amsterdam include:

- **Route 600 – Church Street / Clizbe Avenue Corridor**
Connects residential neighborhoods to St. Mary's Hospital (Memorial Campus), Amsterdam Commons, Amsterdam High School, and Colonial Square Apartments.
- **Route 601 – South Amsterdam / Route 30**
Serves Bridge Street, Market Street, and Wallins Corners Road, with access to William Barkley Elementary School, Market Street businesses, Perth Plaza, and Amsterdam High School.
- **Route 602 – Amsterdam to Schenectady**
Follows Guy Park Avenue, Division Street, East Main Street, and Route 5 and serves St. Mary's Hospital and downtown Schenectady.
- **Route 560 – I-90 Express**
Provides express service connecting downtown Amsterdam to Scotia, Schenectady, and Albany via the New York State Thruway.

CASE STUDY

Downtown Gateway & Complete Streets Initiative

Overview

The Downtown Gateway & Complete Streets Initiative represents one of Amsterdam’s most significant recent investments in walkability, safety, and public realm enhancement. The project focuses on critical entry points into the city—particularly East Main Street, downtown Main Street, and Bridge Street—and is designed to create a more welcoming, connected, and vibrant downtown district.

The project embraces Complete Streets principles to prioritize safe travel for all users, including pedestrians, bicyclists, motorists, and transit riders. Streetscape upgrades include new sidewalks, improved crosswalks, enhanced lighting, street trees, landscaping, and traffic-calming measures. Collectively, these improvements strengthen the visual character of downtown, support local businesses, and enhance accessibility for residents and visitors.

A major component of the initiative is improving the city’s primary commercial corridors to better link neighborhoods with downtown destinations and waterfront amenities. These improvements reinforce the city’s broader goals of expanding multimodal access, reducing vehicle dependency, and creating a high-quality public realm that supports economic revitalization.

Many of the concepts advanced through the Downtown Gateway project complement recommendations in the Downtown Revitalization Initiative (DRI) Strategic Investment Plan, which highlights the importance of safe, walkable streets and improved connectivity between the MVGO Bridge, Chuctanunda Creek Trail, and key community destinations.

THE DOWNTOWN GATEWAY INITIATIVE DEMONSTRATES HOW TARGETED PUBLIC INVESTMENT CAN TRANSFORM HIGH-TRAFFIC CORRIDORS INTO SAFER, MORE ATTRACTIVE, MULTIMODAL STREETS—SUPPORTING WALKABILITY, ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT, AND QUALITY OF LIFE.



Parking

Amsterdam has access to approximately 30 parking lots, totaling roughly 350,000 square feet of parking area. Most local streets also allow on-street parking, providing convenient access for residents, visitors, and businesses.

Downtown Amsterdam includes a multi-tier parking garage attached to the Amsterdam Riverfront Center. Although currently vacant, the structure is highly visible from the city's southern gateway and represents a potential opportunity for future redevelopment or adaptive reuse.

Bicycle Facilities

Amsterdam has limited dedicated bicycle lanes, but the city benefits from the Empire State Trail, a paved off-road trail supporting both pedestrians and cyclists. The trail begins at a designated trailhead on the South Side at Bridge Street and Erie Street, with a bicycle–pedestrian gateway bridge providing direct access to downtown.

As part of the Complete Streets initiative, the City is exploring the development of a Bicycle Boulevard system. This effort includes selecting priority routes, developing outreach materials, and implementing signage and pavement markings to improve visibility and safety for cyclists.

Key Finding: While the Empire State Trail is a regional asset, Amsterdam's on-street bicycle facilities remain limited, underscoring the importance of Complete Streets initiatives.

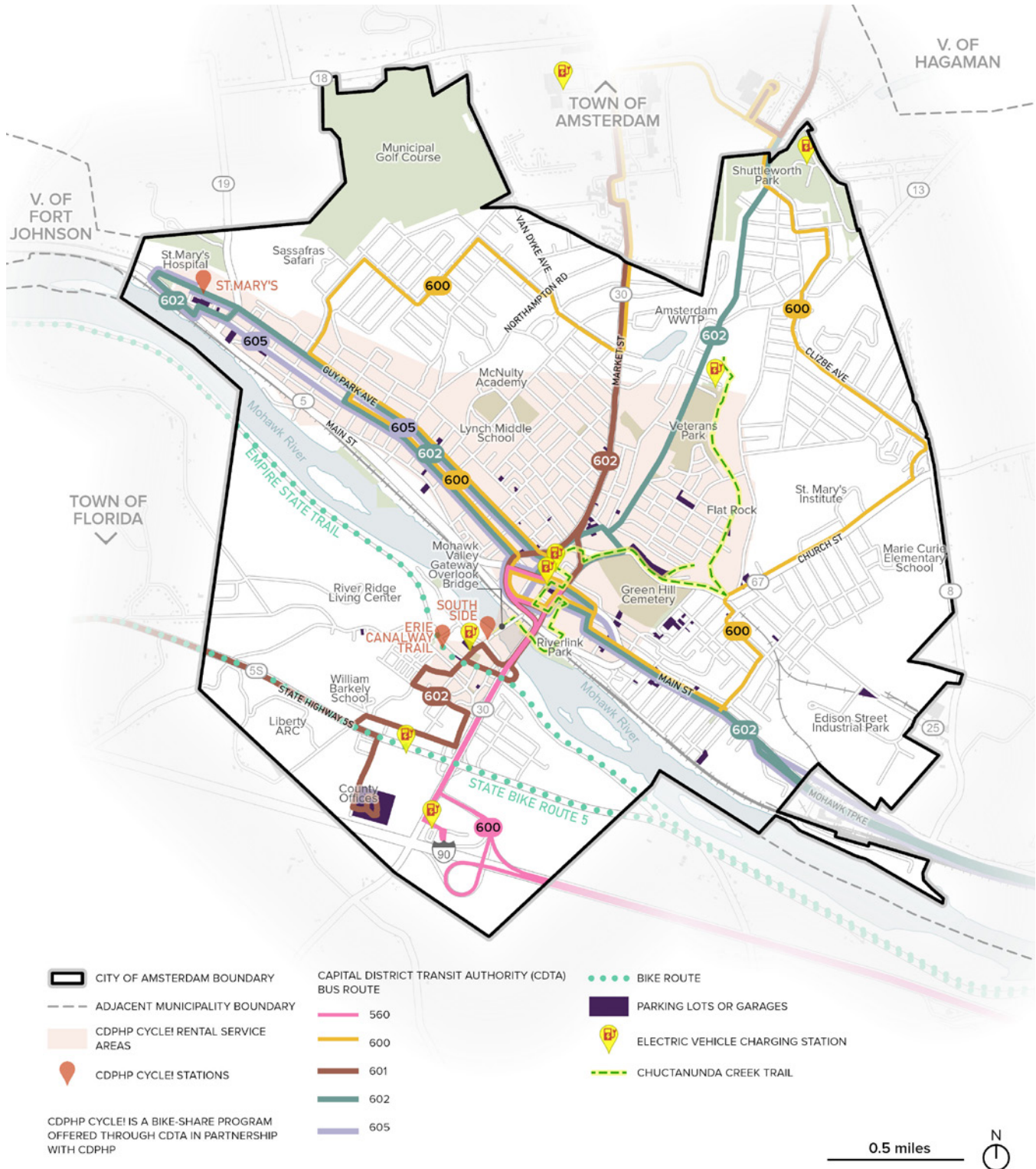
Electric Vehicles (EV) Charging Infrastructure

Amsterdam is part of an expanding electric vehicle (EV) charging network in the Mohawk Valley. Investments in EV infrastructure support statewide goals for zero-emission vehicles and increase charging access for local residents, commuters, and visitors.

The city now hosts more than 50 public charging ports (Level 2 and Level 3), located across several public and private sites, including:

- NYS Thruway Park and Ride – 1 station
- Microtel Inn & Suites – 2 stations
- Bridge Street Parking Lot – 3 stations
- Veddersburg Apartments – 2 stations
- Amsterdam Library Lot – 2 stations
- Amsterdam Public Safety Building – 2 stations
- Veterans Memorial Park (South Lot) – 5 stations
- Veterans Memorial Park (North Lot) – 5 stations
- KLV Properties, Clizbe Avenue – 2 stations
- Shuttleworth Park – 5 stations

Transportation Assets Map



COMMUNITY PROFILE

Infrastructure

As an urban center, the City of Amsterdam was designed to support a much larger population and industrial base than exists today. As a result, the city benefits from extensive utility infrastructure, including water, sewer, gas, electric, and telecommunications systems, that is currently underutilized but well positioned to accommodate future residential, commercial, and industrial growth. The following section describes existing infrastructure assets and planned investments that will help modernize and strengthen these systems.

Water & Sewer

Amsterdam's water supply originates from three impounding reservoirs located at the foothills of the Adirondack Mountains in Saratoga County. Together, these reservoirs have a storage capacity of approximately 10 million gallons and serve a broader population of roughly 21,000 residents. Current water demand is approximately 5.4 million gallons per day, well below system capacity.

Raw water enters a 24-inch transmission pipe, where it is screened, metered, and disinfected with chlorine dioxide before traveling approximately 15 miles to the City. Amsterdam recently upgraded its water filtration facilities with Trident up-flow clarification, carbon contactors, and other improvements to enhance water treatment performance. The Water Filtration Plant operates continuously and has a design capacity of 12 MGD, with an average daily demand of around 5 MGD, leaving abundant room for future development.

Similarly, Amsterdam's wastewater treatment plant has a design capacity of 10 MGD and currently operates at an average flow of approximately 5 MGD. The plant is capable of supporting new housing, industry, and commercial development without requiring major capacity expansions.

Amsterdam remains in full compliance with all State and Federal regulations, and the City reported no contaminant or turbidity violations in 2023.

Key Finding: Amsterdam's water and wastewater systems operate at roughly half their design capacity, positioning the city well for new growth and redevelopment.

State Investment in Water Infrastructure

In 2023, Amsterdam received a \$10 million clean water grant from the New York State Department of Environmental Conservation (NYSDEC) as part of a statewide \$166 million investment in water quality. This funding will support critical improvements to the city's water and wastewater systems, including modernization of outdated components, expansion of treatment capacity, and upgrades designed to protect the health of the Mohawk River. These investments strengthen long-term system reliability and environmental resilience while enhancing the city's ability to support future residential and economic development.

Gas & Electric

Electricity and natural gas service in Amsterdam are provided by National Grid, which maintains distribution infrastructure throughout the city. The utility network is supported by long-standing rights-of-way and service corridors, providing reliable energy access for homes, businesses, and industrial sites.

Tele-Communications

Amsterdam is served by a range of telecommunications providers, including Spectrum, Frontier, Verizon, HughesNet, Viasat, and T-Mobile. Broadband access is widely available through private carriers; however, municipal broadband is not currently available within the city. As demand for high-speed internet continues to increase for residents, businesses, and remote workers, communications infrastructure will remain a key consideration for future investment.

CASE STUDY

Clean Water Infrastructure Investment

Overview

In 2023, the City of Amsterdam secured a transformative \$10 million clean water grant from the New York State Department of Environmental Conservation (NYSDEC), part of a statewide \$166 million initiative to advance water quality and environmental health across New York. This award represents a major milestone for Amsterdam's water and wastewater systems and marks one of the largest infrastructure reinvestments in the city in recent years.

The funding will support a comprehensive series of upgrades to Amsterdam's water and wastewater treatment facilities. Planned improvements include modernization of aging system components, expansion of treatment capacity, and enhancements to the filtration and disinfection processes that protect public health. These upgrades will help safeguard the quality of the Mohawk River—one of the city's defining natural resources—while reinforcing the reliability of the municipal water system for current and future users.

The investment also strengthens the city's capacity for long-term growth. With water and wastewater plants currently operating at roughly half their design capacity, the planned improvements will enhance operational efficiency, extend system lifespan, and ensure that residential and economic development can occur without placing undue strain on essential infrastructure. This positions Amsterdam to support new housing, commercial redevelopment, and industrial projects for decades to come.

Beyond system performance, these improvements contribute to broader environmental resilience goals. Modernized water infrastructure reduces the likelihood of service disruptions, improves energy efficiency, and enhances the city's ability to adapt to changing climate conditions such as increased precipitation and stormwater runoff.

This state investment reflects a statewide commitment to clean water and acknowledges Amsterdam's proactive approach to upgrading critical public infrastructure. The improvements funded through this grant will help ensure reliable, high-quality water service for residents and businesses while supporting the city's long-term revitalization objectives.

COMMUNITY PROFILE

Environmental Conditions

Natural resources play a vital role in shaping the environmental health, character, and livability of the City of Amsterdam. The presence of vibrant waterfronts, natural landscapes, high-quality water resources, and clean air directly influences community well-being. The following section describes key natural resources and environmental features within the city.

Water Resources

One of Amsterdam's most significant natural resources is the Mohawk River, which flows through the center of the city and has played a defining role in its history, industry, and identity. Together with Chuctanunda Creek, these waterways supported the mills and factories that fueled Amsterdam's early economic expansion.

The Mohawk River spans roughly 140 miles and drains a watershed of more than 3,400 square miles before joining the Hudson River. The North Chuctanunda Creek enters the city near Shuttleworth Park, flowing south (underground in sections) before meeting the Mohawk.

Both waterways are classified as Class C waterbodies, supporting fisheries and non-contact recreation. They remain important environmental, recreational, and redevelopment assets.

Key Finding: The Mohawk River and Chuctanunda Creek are vital ecological and economic resources that continue to shape Amsterdam's environmental and redevelopment priorities.

Bunn Creek and Auifers

Bunn Creek flows south through Amsterdam to the Mohawk River, with its northern portion designated Class A and its southern portion Class C. The creek is protected under the NYSDEC Protection of Waters Program due to its environmental significance.

Although shallow and non-navigable in many areas, Bunn Creek supports local wildlife and recreational fishing. Mapping from NYSDEC and the U.S. Geological Survey indicates the city is not located over a primary aquifer, though unconfined aquifers in some areas remain more vulnerable to contamination.

Key Finding: Bunn Creek is an ecologically important waterway with state-level protections, despite the city's limited reliance on local aquifer systems.



Chuctanunda Creek (MP Photography)

Floodplains

FEMA identifies Special Flood Hazard Areas within Amsterdam mainly along the Mohawk River, Chuctanunda Creek, and Bunn Creek. While much of the city lies outside these areas, several flood-prone corridors contain Regulatory Floodways or 1% annual chance zones.

Citywide, Amsterdam contains 473.1 acres of mapped flood hazard areas, including 284.3 acres of Regulatory Floodway where development is limited to preserve natural function.

Key Finding: Flood risks in Amsterdam are concentrated along key waterways, making flood-aware design and land use practices essential.

Severe Weather & Climate Considerations

Amsterdam experiences a range of severe weather events, including flooding, heavy snow, ice storms, and extreme temperature, that can disrupt infrastructure and services. These events have caused road closures, power outages, drainage issues, and damage to utilities.

Climate trends indicate increasing precipitation intensity and temperature extremes, elevating risks to natural systems, transportation networks, and local economic activity.

Key Finding: Amsterdam is advancing resilience-focused planning efforts to better protect residents, infrastructure, and natural resources from climate impacts.

Wetlands

Amsterdam contains approximately 255 acres of USFWS-classified wetlands and 42 acres of NYSDEC-regulated wetlands, primarily along the Mohawk River. These wetlands provide ecological benefits such as habitat, flood mitigation, and water filtration. NYSDEC wetlands include a 100-foot regulatory check zone, requiring verification for potential development.

Key Finding: The city's wetland systems provide critical ecological and flood mitigation functions, particularly along the Mohawk River.

Threatened & Endangered Species

Based on USFWS IPaC data, Amsterdam may host several protected species, including the Northern Long-eared Bat, Tricolored Bat, and Monarch Butterfly. A number of migratory birds protected under federal regulations may also occur within the city. No critical habitats are designated within Amsterdam.

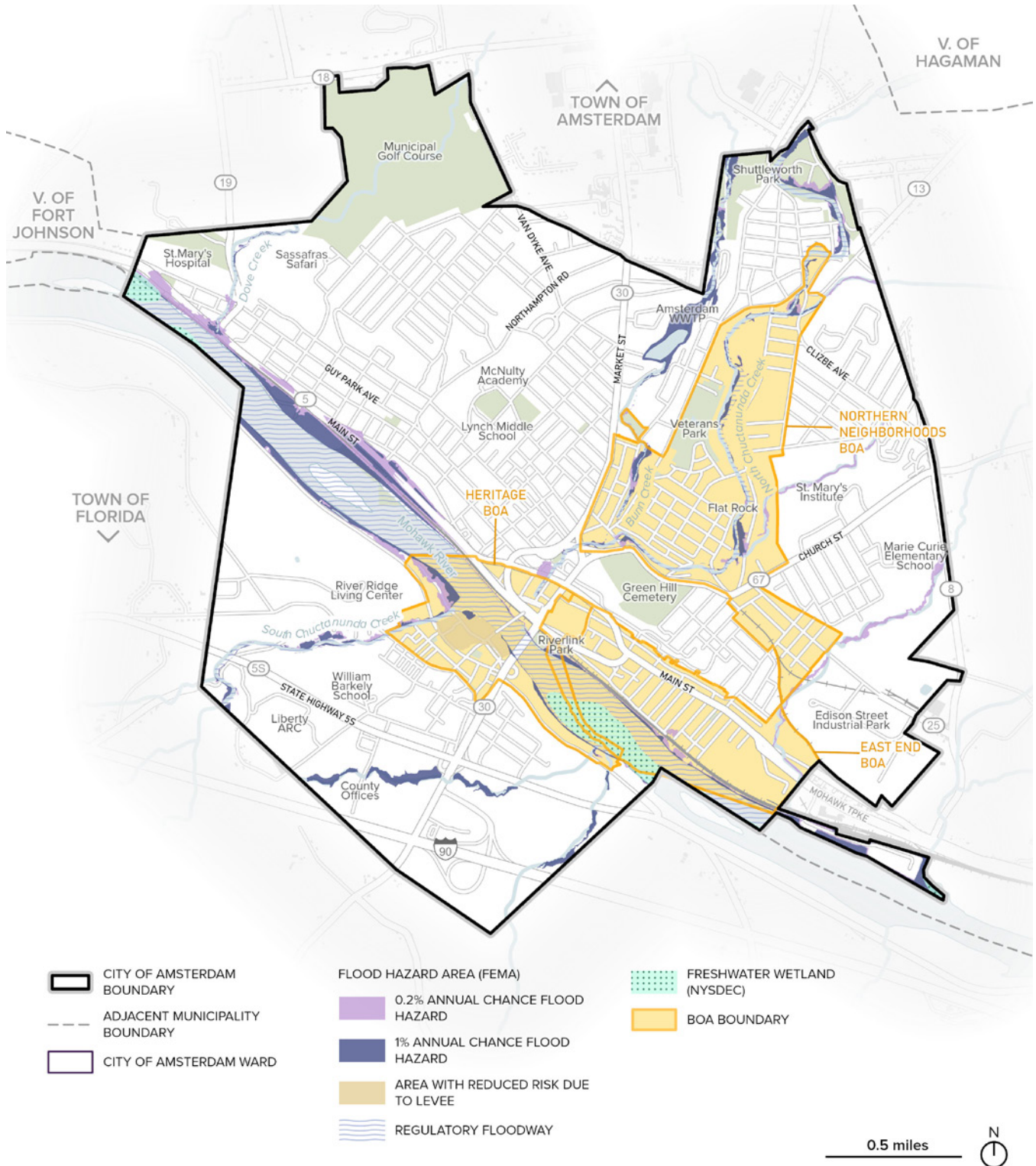
Key Finding: Several protected species may be present in Amsterdam, reinforcing the importance of preserving habitat corridors along waterways.

Environmental Contamination & Brownfields

Amsterdam's industrial heritage has resulted in numerous properties potentially affected by contamination. Over 500 acres have been studied through the NYS Brownfield Opportunity Area (BOA) Program, identifying more than 100 sites as vacant, underutilized, or potentially contaminated.

Key Finding: Amsterdam's extensive brownfield areas present significant redevelopment potential when supported by environmental remediation.

Environmental Features Map



An aerial photograph of Amsterdam, Ohio, showing a river flowing through the town, surrounded by green hills and residential areas. The image is partially covered by a dark purple overlay on the left side.

03

Our Vision for the Future

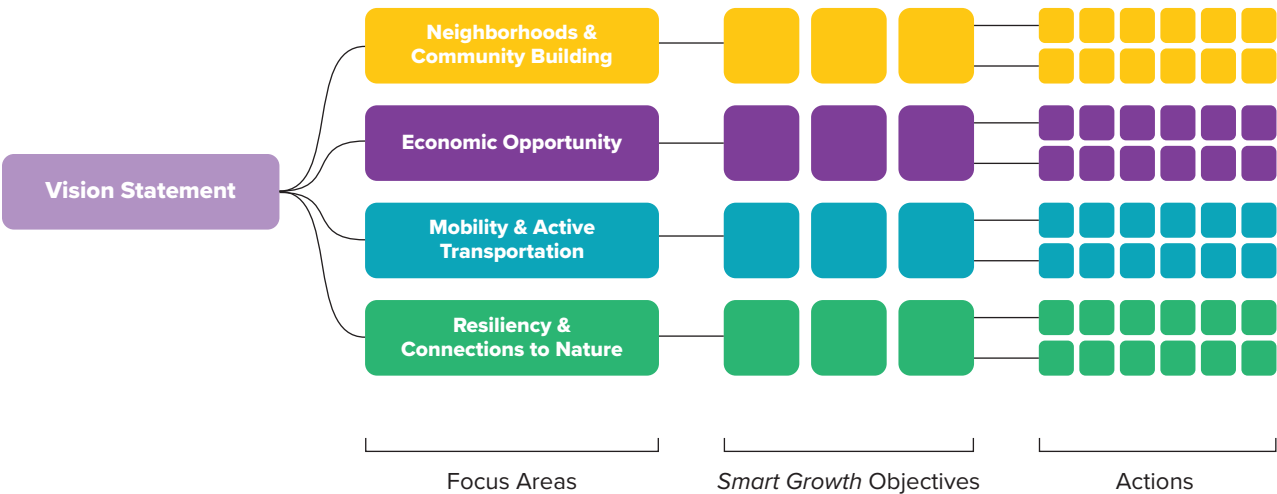
Our vision and objectives for the next 10 years in Amsterdam.



VISION FRAMEWORK

Overview

The vision framework outlines important focus areas, objectives, and actions necessary to achieve Amsterdam’s vision for the future.



- Vision** The vision is a general statement that describes the City’s aspirations; it is an end toward which all actions are aimed. The vision should not dramatically change over time, but rather it should be consistent throughout the ten-year planning horizon.
- Focus Areas** Focus areas represent specific topics of interest where the City will focus attention and efforts to achieve a set of objectives. Amsterdam’s focus areas include: Neighborhoods & Community Building, Economic Opportunity, Mobility & Active Transportation, and Resiliency & Connections to Nature.
- Smart Growth Objectives** An objective is a specific, measurable goal targeted at a particular focus area. Objectives outline concrete steps that can be taken to move focus areas toward their desired future state. The objectives used in this Plan are based on the Smart Growth principles identified on Page X.
- Actions** Actions are specific recommendations that are designed to help accomplish an objective. Actions can take the form of a plan, project, or program. The lifespan of an action item can vary from one to ten years depending on the item. Recommended actions can be found in **Section 4: Our Roadmap for Action.**

VISION FRAMEWORK

Vision Statement

The City of Amsterdam’s vision for the future is described below.

Today

Amsterdam is experiencing a resurgence. We are working to revitalize our downtown, enhance our waterfront, strengthen our neighborhoods, and change our image for the better. We recognize that there is more work to do, but we will build on our long history of community planning and leverage our recent successes to carry today’s momentum forward to redefine Amsterdam for tomorrow.

Our vision for

Tomorrow

The City of Amsterdam is a complete community with something for everyone. It is known across the Capital Region as the place to be – the place to live, the place to work, the place you have to visit. Our strong neighborhoods are great places to live and residents are proud to call Amsterdam “home.” Amsterdam is the perfect place to start or grow a business. We have a talented workforce and job opportunities in every industry and skill-level. Our vibrant downtown and waterfront make Amsterdam a must-visit tourist destination, with arts, entertainment, and recreation options for everyone. Our community is well-connected and multi-modal and it’s safe and convenient to get around by foot, bike, bus, or car. Our unique identity and strong sense of community make Amsterdam a special place to be. Our quality of life is unmatched, and we are committed to sustainability and resiliency for the health of our community today and tomorrow.

Focus Areas

In planning for this future, we will pursue a series of Smart Growth objectives across four focus areas:



Neighborhoods & Community Building. This focus area deals with the building blocks of our communities, including housing, neighborhoods, and people.



Economic Opportunity. This focus area centers on elements that impact our economy, such as businesses, job opportunities, tourism, and development.



Mobility & Active Transportation. This focus area promotes safe connections through walkability, bike-ability, and multi-modal transportation access.



Resiliency & Connections to Nature. This focus area concentrates on the sustainability of our environment, including parks, waterfronts, and natural resources.

Each focus area is explored in more detail on the following pages.

FOCUS AREA 01



Neighborhoods & Community Building

This focus area deals with the building blocks of our communities, including housing, neighborhoods, and people.

Today

Today, one of Amsterdam's biggest impediments to growth is its lack of suitable housing for every demographic. Beyond single-family homes and duplexes, there is limited diversity in housing types. Additionally, the housing stock is aging, and new construction has been sluggish since the early 2000s. The City is actively pursuing several initiatives to support strong neighborhoods, including demolishing blighted structures and rehabilitating homes through the Community Development Block Grant program, but there's more work to be done to make Amsterdam a livable community for everyone.

Our vision for Tomorrow

Amsterdam sets itself apart as a favorite hometown choice in the Capital District. Anyone who wants to live in Amsterdam can find housing that meets their needs. Whether that is a first rental, a "forever" home, or a retirement community, Amsterdam has diverse and affordable housing options for everyone at all stages of life. The City's neighborhoods are compact and walkable, with plenty of amenities and a strong sense of community that makes residents proud to call Amsterdam "home."

Objectives

To achieve this vision for tomorrow, we will pursue the following Smart Growth objectives:

- 01 Enable a diverse mix of housing types, providing opportunity and choice for all.** In Amsterdam, this means expanding the types of housing options and price ranges available so that anyone who wants to live in Amsterdam can find a place that meets their needs.
- 02 Encourage compact neighborhood design and concentrated development around existing infrastructure.** In Amsterdam, this involves making our neighborhoods great places to live by infusing them with amenities like sidewalks, bikeways, and open space and making sure they are located close by to everyday services.
- 03 Engage in an inclusive, collaborative public planning process that considers the needs and character of the community.** In Amsterdam, this involves leveraging our strong history of community planning and continuing to engage residents in building the future of Amsterdam together.
- 04 Promote homeownership opportunities.** Work with the land bank and other non-profits, such as Better Neighborhoods Inc. and the Affordable Housing Partnership of the Capital Region, to rehabilitate housing that is affordable for renters to own.



FOCUS AREA 02

Economic Opportunity

This focus area centers on elements that impact our economy, such as businesses, job opportunities, tourism, and development.

Today

Amsterdam's legacy of manufacturing served as the foundation of our economy for many generations. Today, our economy has shifted toward lower-wage industries. Unemployment is high, median household incomes are low, and many families struggle to support themselves. Limited employment opportunities in the city result in many of our residents commuting outside Amsterdam for work. However, in recent years, our business community has been growing and we are working to support small businesses through initiatives like our Microenterprise Assistance Program. We also see opportunities to revitalize our historic building stock and reuse underutilized parking lots in the downtown core for new mixed-use developments.

Our vision for

Tomorrow

Amsterdam has a diverse mix of industries and job opportunities at all skill levels. More residents than ever are staying in the city to work, and others from outside the city are attracted to Amsterdam for its job opportunities. Our business-friendly policies and talented workforce make Amsterdam a great place to grow or start a business. We have transformed our downtown into a vibrant mixed-use center by rehabilitating existing buildings and infilling vacant lots with new developments. Our waterfront is revitalized too, with new amenities and programming to complement Riverlink Park, the MVGO Bridge, and the Empire State Trail. Amsterdam continues to be a must-visit tourist destination, with a strong arts and cultural scene, unique festivals and events, and entertainment and recreation options for everyone.

Objectives

To achieve this vision for tomorrow, we will pursue the following Smart Growth objectives:

- 01 Develop plans and land use regulations that allow for and revitalize mixed-use neighborhoods.** In Amsterdam, this means the rehab and infill of underutilized lots in existing mixed-use areas, revitalizing our historic downtown building stock, and strengthening our downtown core with new uses and amenities that make downtown a great place to live, work, and play.
- 02 Build on unique traits to create an attractive and welcoming community with a strong sense of place.** In Amsterdam, this means continuing to support Amsterdam's existing strengths, like our vibrant events scene and our strong cultural diversity, while at the same time changing Amsterdam's reputation for the better and redefining the city as a community of choice, with a strong downtown and great neighborhoods.

FOCUS AREA 03



Mobility & Active Transportation

This focus area promotes safe connections through walkability, bike-ability, and multi-modal transportation access.

Today

Though Amsterdam was originally developed with a traditional grid, the proliferation of the automobile and the construction of the highways eroded over time the walkability the city used to have. Today, limited facilities for pedestrians and cyclists make the city less walkable and bikeable than it could be. An over-abundance of underutilized surface parking and vacant lots disrupt the feel and character of downtown. The City recognizes these issues and has been working to address them. Plans are in the works to remove the eastbound portion of NYS Route 5 and replace it with a multi-modal hub. Active projects also include streetscape and complete streets enhancements, gateway improvements, and trail enhancements to promote increased connectivity and multi-modal access throughout the city.

Our vision for Tomorrow

Amsterdam is a city where it is safe and convenient to get around by foot, bike, bus, or car. Our streetscapes are pedestrian-friendly, our trails and bikeways are expansive, and our transit service is convenient and reliable. The Amsterdam Multi-modal Station provides downtown access to Amtrak train service and a new pedestrian connector significantly improves access to the MVGO bridge. Downtown is compact and walkable with vacant lots being replaced by mixed-use buildings. Signage and wayfinding elements help visitors get around. Our neighborhoods are well connected to each other and to local and regional destinations.

Objectives

To achieve this vision for tomorrow, we will pursue the following Smart Growth objectives:

- 01 Prioritize transportation options such as walking, cycling, and public transportation.** In Amsterdam, this means creating safe connections for all modes of transportation by enhancing our streetscapes, expanding trails and bikeways, improving mass-transit options and reliability, traffic calming, and making directional signage and wayfinding easier to understand.
- 02 Prioritize infill and redevelopment of existing buildings to revitalize neighborhoods and downtowns, including areas around public transit.** In Amsterdam, this means focusing development in well-connected areas, including near the Amsterdam Multi-modal Station, to encourage alternative transportation and reduce car dependency.
- 03 Increase traffic enforcement.** Enhance road safety and protect our communities by implementing smart traffic monitoring systems. Leverage technologies like automated speed cameras to consistently enforce traffic laws—including speed limits, stop signs, and traffic signals. Consider evaluating speed limits in high-risk areas to better match road conditions and pedestrian activity.

FOCUS AREA 04



Resiliency & Connections to Nature

This focus area concentrates on the sustainability of our environment, including parks, waterfronts, and natural resources.

Today

Amsterdam has a wealth of natural resources including public green spaces, parks, and scenic waterfronts along the Mohawk River and Chuctanunda Creek. Our city recognizes the vital role that natural resources play in our environment, community well-being, and tourism. We are committed to protecting and improving them. Through our updated Local Waterfront Revitalization Program (LWRP), we are actively trying new approaches to enhance our waterfront. Additionally, we are working to improve the city's environmental health by cleaning up and redeveloping brownfields, like the Five Corners site, through the Brownfield Opportunity Area (BOA) program.

Our vision for Tomorrow

Amsterdam thrives as a sustainable, forward-thinking community. We have proactively addressed future climate risks, safeguarding our property, infrastructure, and vulnerable residents. Our waterfront has blossomed into a vibrant tourist destination, offering expanded amenities, diverse programming, and a stronger connection to downtown. Our extensive network of trails and bike paths caters to active lifestyles, while our public green spaces serve as vital community gathering points. Committed to a lasting legacy, we will continue to protect and enhance the Mohawk River, Chuctanunda Creek, and our environment for future generations.

Objectives

To achieve this vision for tomorrow, we will pursue the following Smart Growth objectives:

- 01 Provide well-planned, equitable, and accessible public spaces.** In Amsterdam, this means enhancing our waterfront and existing public green spaces with new amenities, connecting them to our neighborhoods with trails and bikeways, and expanding recreational offerings to promote healthy living.
- 02 Preserve open space, agricultural resources, and natural resources.** In Amsterdam, this means protecting and preserving our existing natural resources, including our waterfronts and green spaces, so that they can continue to contribute to the environmental health of our community.
- 03 Promote climate resiliency and adaptation, preferably through nature-based solutions, and reduce greenhouse gas emissions.** In Amsterdam, this involves making our urban environment healthier and more resilient by implementing green infrastructure, expanding our tree canopy, and supporting clean energy options.

04

Our Community Development Strategy

Amsterdam's future land use vision
and recommendations.



COMMUNITY DEVELOPMENT STRATEGY

Introduction

Future land use and development decisions will play an important role in the achievement of Amsterdam’s vision and goals. While land use and the physical transformation of places and spaces within the City are intricately connected to each other and are considered in the identification of policies and actions, the physical evolution of land within the City is a unique community development consideration.

As such, this section of the Plan focuses on the physical characteristics of the City of Amsterdam from a land use, design, and development character perspective. This includes a City-wide Community Development Strategy (CDS) and Map with defined character areas, as well as land use goals and recommendations associated with other key urban design, smart growth, and place-making elements.

The **CDS Character Areas** for the City of Amsterdam are listed at right and shown on the map on the following page. The delineation of these areas is based on a balance of factors, considering existing land uses and determining areas where preservation, stabilization, and/or transformation may be desired.

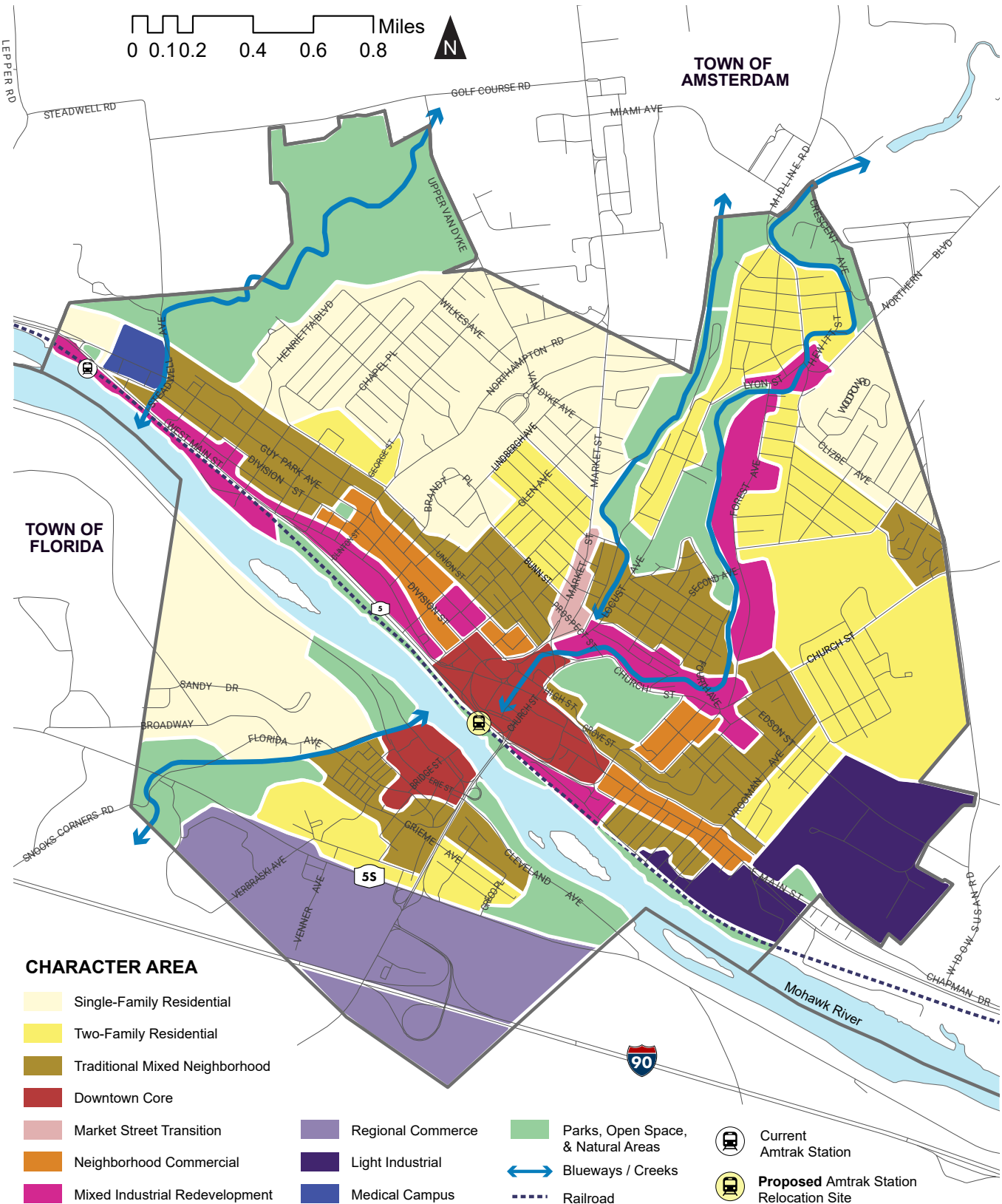
Unlike a zoning map, the CDS Map is not intended to represent clear regulatory boundaries. The shape of each area and placement of boundaries may change as new information or investment opportunities arise.

While future decision-making may not always perfectly align with the CDS, such decisions, should remain consistent with the overall intent of this Plan. They should be grounded with well-considered rationale and careful consideration given to community impact and logical transitions or buffers between character areas, where necessary.

- | | |
|----------------------------|---|
| Neighborhoods | <ul style="list-style-type: none">• Single-Family Residential• Two-Family Residential• Traditional Mixed Neighborhood |
| Downtown | <ul style="list-style-type: none">• Downtown Core• Market Street Transition |
| Mixed Use Corridors | <ul style="list-style-type: none">• Neighborhood Commercial• Mixed Industrial Redevelopment |
| Industry Centers | <ul style="list-style-type: none">• Regional Commerce• Light Industrial• Medical Campus |
| Natural Environment | <ul style="list-style-type: none">• Parks & Greenspace• Waterfront & Blueways |

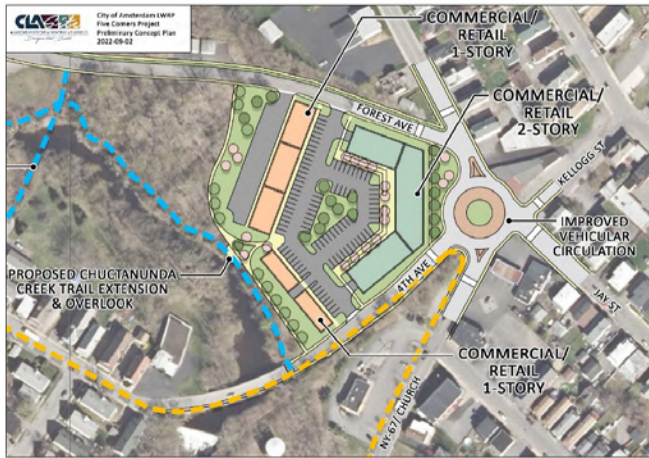
NOTE: The CDS does not negate any development limitations due to environmental constraints, such as steep slopes or floodplains. As future projects are considered, a more detailed study of existing conditions and suitability of the site for the uses proposed may need to be completed.

Community Development Strategy Map



COMMUNITY DEVELOPMENT STRATEGY

Land Use Guide for Smart Growth



Amsterdam LWRP Priority Project | Five Corners Plaza & Intersection

Economic Development & Reinvestment

Focus: Leveraging existing spaces and resources.

- Concentrate commercial uses and employment opportunities in visible, accessible economic activity centers
- Support small businesses, local services, and entrepreneurship through flexible building formats and mixed uses
- Encourage reinvestment in underutilized and aging commercial and industrial properties without expanding into greenfield areas



Vetersburg Apartments (Source: Apartments.com)

Housing Choice & Neighborhood Stability

Focus: Attracting and retaining residents.

- Introduce higher density housing opportunities near services and transit
- Provide a range of housing types that support workforce retention, aging in place, and changing household needs
- Reduce development pressure within stable residential neighborhoods by accommodating growth along mixed use corridors



Downtown Multimodal Center Final Concept



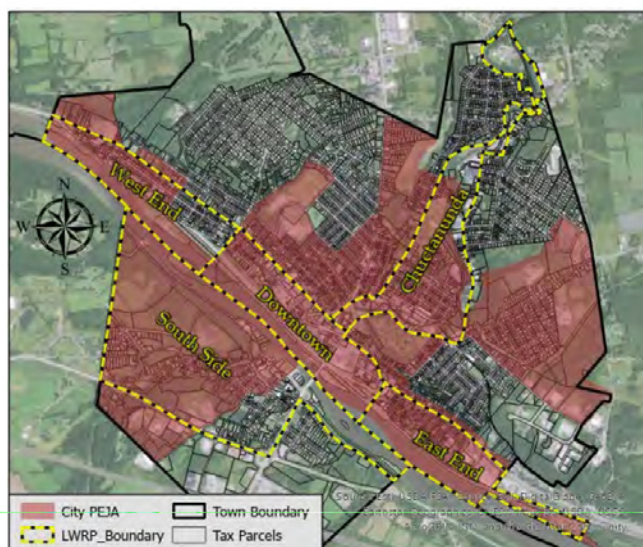
Transportation & Mobility

Focus: Accessibility for all modes of travel and reduced car dependence.

- Foster multimodal spines that prioritize safe access for pedestrians, cyclists, transit users, and vehicles
- Maintain vehicle traffic enforcement for safety of pedestrians and bicyclists
- Improve connections between Downtown, neighborhood centers, institutional uses, and employment areas, including the Route 30 corridor
- Support transit-oriented development and reduce reliance on single-occupancy vehicles

Amtrak Station Relocation

The Amtrak Station is proposed to be relocated closer to downtown. This is a great opportunity for more Transit Oriented Development and infill.



Potential Environmental Justice Areas | Amsterdam LWRP

Equity & Access to Services

Focus: Supporting disadvantaged populations.

- Improve access to jobs, housing, healthcare, education, and daily needs for residents
- Ensure community services and amenities are located along mixed use corridors that are accessible to all residents
- Pursue equitable reinvestment in historically disinvested areas

NYS Grant Opportunities

Several NYS grant programs give preference to proposed projects and planning efforts in state defined Environmental Justice Areas. Much of Amsterdam qualifies for this designation (see left).

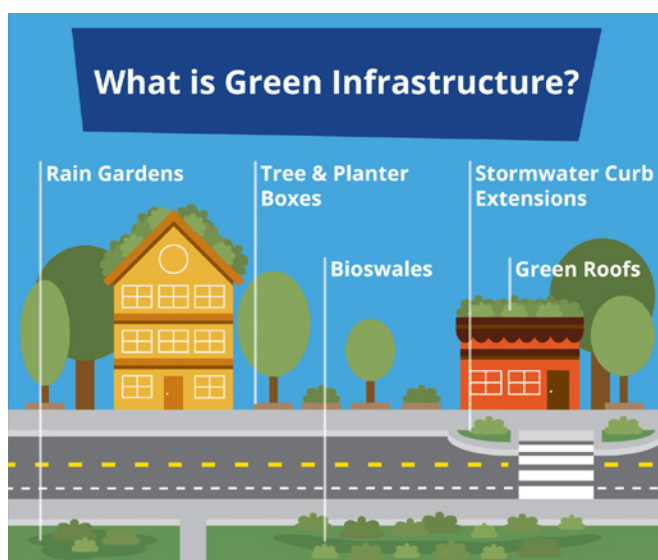


Example transition treatments between residential and nonresidential.

Land Use Compatibility & Transitions

Focus: Logical, harmonic arrangement of land uses.

- Serve as intentional transition areas between higher-intensity commercial or Downtown uses and surrounding neighborhoods
- Allow increased density and mixed uses in appropriate locations while protecting neighborhood scale and livability
- Provide opportunities for buffering, step-downs, and context-sensitive design



Source: Save the Bay (savesfbay.org)

Environmental Sustainability & Resilience

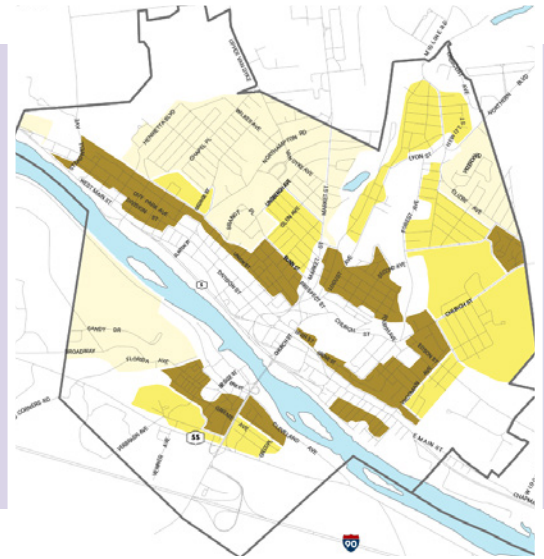
Focus: Climate adaptation and mitigation measures.

- Support compact development patterns that reduce infrastructure costs and environmental impacts
- Integrate green infrastructure, street trees, and stormwater management into corridor design
- Align with Greenway and Blueway connections to enhance environmental and recreational benefits

COMMUNITY DEVELOPMENT STRATEGY

Neighborhoods

Successful redevelopment efforts depend on a community's ability to maintain and improve its quality of life. Neighborhoods stand at the core of any growth effort; people live in neighborhoods and orient their activities from neighborhoods. If a city's neighborhoods are not safe and attractive, people with choices look elsewhere for housing, work, recreation and shopping. It is the goal of Amsterdam to leverage the City's historic, varied housing stock and established neighborhoods to attract and retain new residents of all ages, incomes, and lifestyles.



Single-Family Residential

The Single-Family Residential areas of the City are comprised predominantly of single-family homes built after 1940. These neighborhoods are primarily located at the outer edges of the City and are more auto-dependent than the traditional neighborhoods as they have varying access to sidewalks and nearby amenities. The typical lot size ranges from 1/4 to 1/2 acre. These tend to be the more stable neighborhoods in the City with a higher rate of home-ownership. Although these neighborhoods are primarily built out, investment in existing housing stock is needed. Goals for these areas include:

- Preservation of neighborhood character while allowing modest density increases (e.g. permitting single-family attached dwellings or cottage court style arrangements).
- Improved pedestrian and bicycle connectivity in outer neighborhoods.
- Targeted traffic-calming treatments on streets experiencing high speed cut-through traffic (e.g. Chapel Place and VanDyke Ave).
- Continued prohibition of the conversion of large estate homes to multi-family.
- Increased owner occupancy rate.
- Preservation and restoration of historic structures.

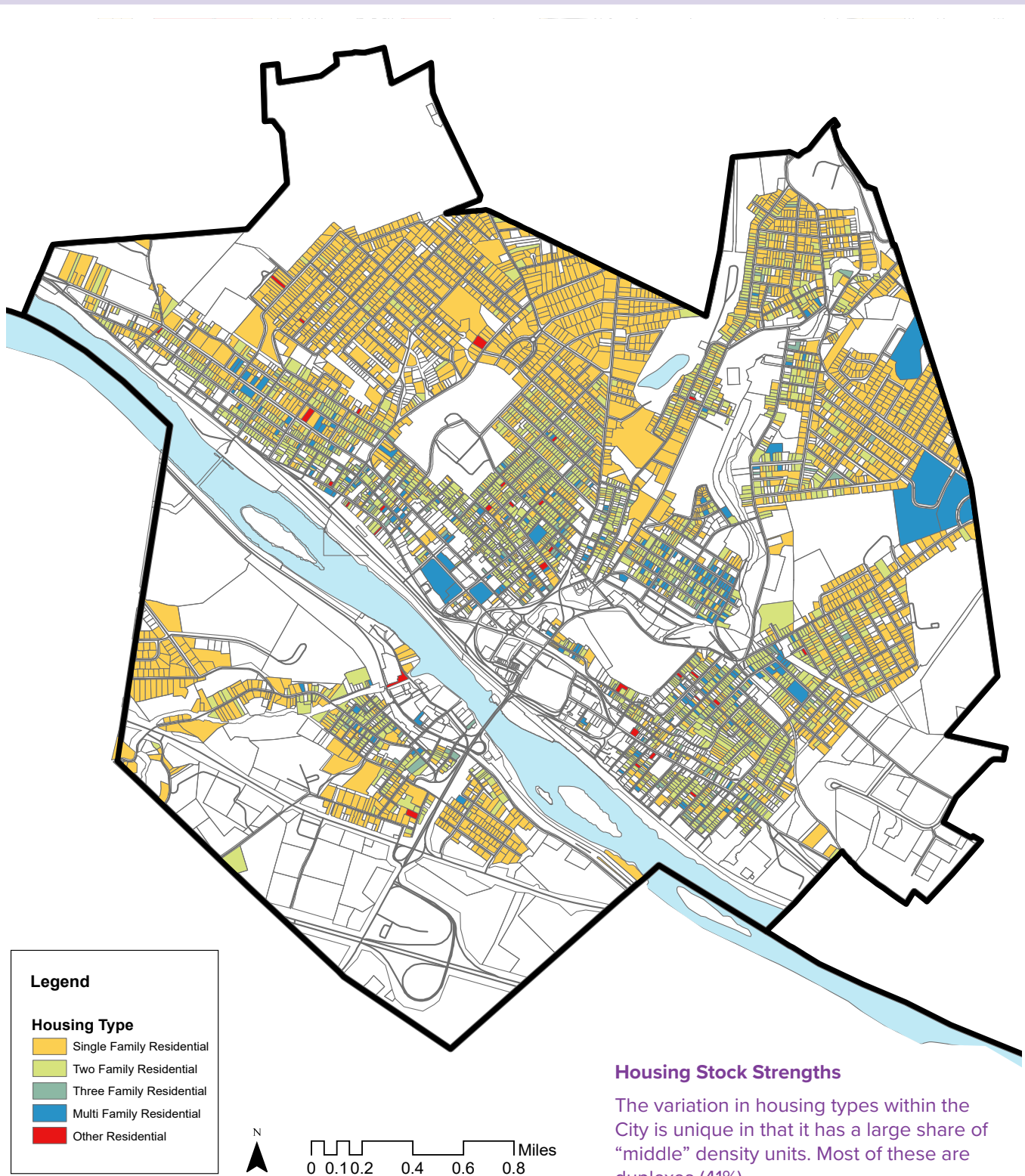
Two-Family Residential

The Two-Family Residential areas are generally traditional, walkable neighborhoods that include both single- and two-family dwellings. These areas serve as a gradual transition between single-family neighborhoods and higher-density mixed residential areas. The typical lot size ranges from 1/8 to 1/2 acre. Much of these neighborhoods include historic, built-as duplexes on traditional city lots. These neighborhoods are at a tipping point and should be a focus for stabilization, as the rate of investment and owner-occupancy has been declining.

Goals for these areas include those listed for the Single-Family Residential areas, as well as:

- Supporting reinvestment, owner-occupancy, and context-sensitive infill that preserves neighborhood character while expanding housing choice.
- Allowing for accessory dwelling units to support aging-in-place and passive income opportunities for home-owners.

Existing Residential Densities Map



COMMUNITY DEVELOPMENT STRATEGY

Traditional Mixed Residential

Traditional Mixed Residential areas include the oldest and most varied density neighborhoods found in the City. Developed in the early settlement years of the City, pre-car and pre-zoning, the neighborhoods are an organic mix of single-family, two-family, and multi-family housing located near to the City center as well as along transit routes and former industrial employment areas. These neighborhoods have the smallest lot sizes, most under 1/4 acre in size.

Being the oldest share of the housing stock, significant investment is needed in existing homes ranging from major repairs to livability improvements (e.g. half-bath or second bath) and modernizations. Many homes have already been lost to disrepair and neglect, leaving opportunities for infill on vacant lots. Goals for these areas include:

- Expanded housing options affordable to a range of incomes and household types
- Infill development that complements existing scale and design
- Enhanced access to transit, parks, and neighborhood amenities
- Continued building code enforcement and support for investment by home-owners
- Improved pedestrian and bicycle connectivity

STRATEGIES FOR FUTURE RESIDENTIAL INVESTMENT

Neighborhood Stabilization Addressing Vacancy & Decline

1. First-Time Homebuyer & Owner-Occupancy Incentives

Promote first-time homebuyer and owner-occupancy incentives such as down payment and closing cost assistance, low-interest rehabilitation loans, and property tax abatements for owner-occupied homes. Partner with local lenders and state programs to provide homebuyer education and purchase-rehab financing to help convert vacant or rental properties into stable owner-occupied housing. The State of New York Mortgage Agency (SONYMA) includes several low-income and first-time homebuyer finance programs.

2. Targeted Rehabilitation & Code-to-Rehab Program

Focus public investment and incentives on priority neighborhoods and corridors by pairing proactive code enforcement with CDBG efforts, low-interest loans, and technical assistance for small landlords and owner-occupants. This helps correct safety issues while making rehabilitation financially feasible, preventing further abandonment.

3. Vacant Property Acquisition, Land Banking, and Disposition

Expand the use of strategic acquisition and land banking to gain site control of long-term vacant and tax-delinquent properties, particularly near Downtown and mixed-use corridors. Reposition properties for reuse through disposition policies that prioritize local ownership, housing rehabilitation, and infill development.

4. Right-Sized Infill & Adaptive Reuse Zoning

Update zoning and development standards to allow for tiny homes, small-scale multifamily, upper-story residential, and adaptive reuse “by right” in mixed density neighborhoods. Reducing regulatory barriers lowers redevelopment costs and encourages reinvestment in existing buildings rather than demolition or greenfield development.

Middle Density Housing Regulatory Recommendations

The **“middle” density** refers to a range of residential dwellings with multiple units, such as two-family and three-family dwelling units that fall between single-family homes and larger multi-family dwellings. These “middle” density dwellings are common in Amsterdam, often found in walkable neighborhoods alongside single-family homes (see photos below). This type of housing in many communities is considered **“missing”** because traditional zoning regulations implemented by municipalities in the mid- to late-20th century typically excluded them.



In Amsterdam, many of the existing two-family and multi-family dwellings are considered pre-existing nonconforming depending on the zoning district in which they are located. This is both due to the housing type being prohibited and often the property not meeting minimum lot size or width requirements. Updates to the Low Density Neighborhood and Medium Density Neighborhood Districts will be needed to reflect the recommended boundaries of the CDS character areas and “right-size” the minimum lot requirements to reflect existing conditions.



Context Sensitive Design for Infill Development

Appropriate Infill Housing for Traditional Neighborhoods



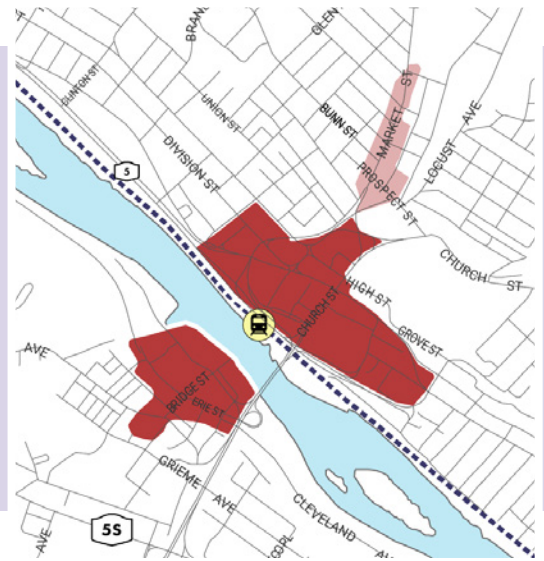
There is a lot of opportunity for infill housing in the City's neighborhoods, which can support more affordable housing options and keep people connected to their neighbors and nearby amenities.

This can be achieved at a variety of scales, ranging from whole blocks to individual vacant lots, each unit appropriately designed to fit into the character of the existing neighborhood. Below are some examples of how this may be achieved with infill of middle density housing on vacant lots.

COMMUNITY DEVELOPMENT STRATEGY

Downtown

Downtown Amsterdam has historically served as the civic, commercial, and cultural heart of the City, shaping settlement patterns by concentrating jobs, services, and institutions along the Mohawk River and the City's traditional street network. Continuing to leverage previous planning successes will be imperative to reinforcing the downtown's role as the central hub of the City and anchor for growth. Future investment should balance the "old" with the "new," accommodating multi-story, mixed use development in a compact, walkable setting that strengthens community identity and reduces pressure on surrounding neighborhoods.



Downtown Core

Existing Conditions

- Historic, compact core with civic, cultural, and commercial functions
- Traditional, walkable street grid with strong pedestrian orientation
- Underutilized upper floors and some vacant or under-performing properties

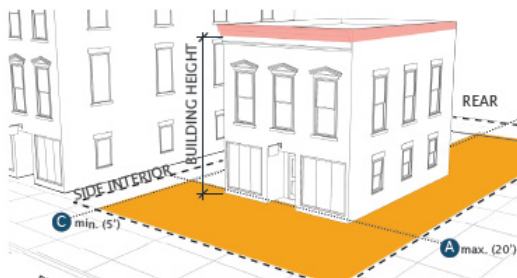
General Future Land Use Goals

- Reinforced role as the City's primary mixed-use, employment, and cultural center
- Expanded residential presence through upper-story housing
- Enhanced public realm with streetscape improvements, wayfinding, and public spaces
- Filling in the "gaps" in the City's downtown urban fabric through redevelopment and infill projects consistent with the Form-Based Code Design Guidelines
- Work with owners and developers to plan and implement the eventual replacement of the former mall and superblocks with a small block street grid development pattern with mixed-use, multi-story buildings

Market Street Transition



Form-Based Code | Building Design - Infill Example

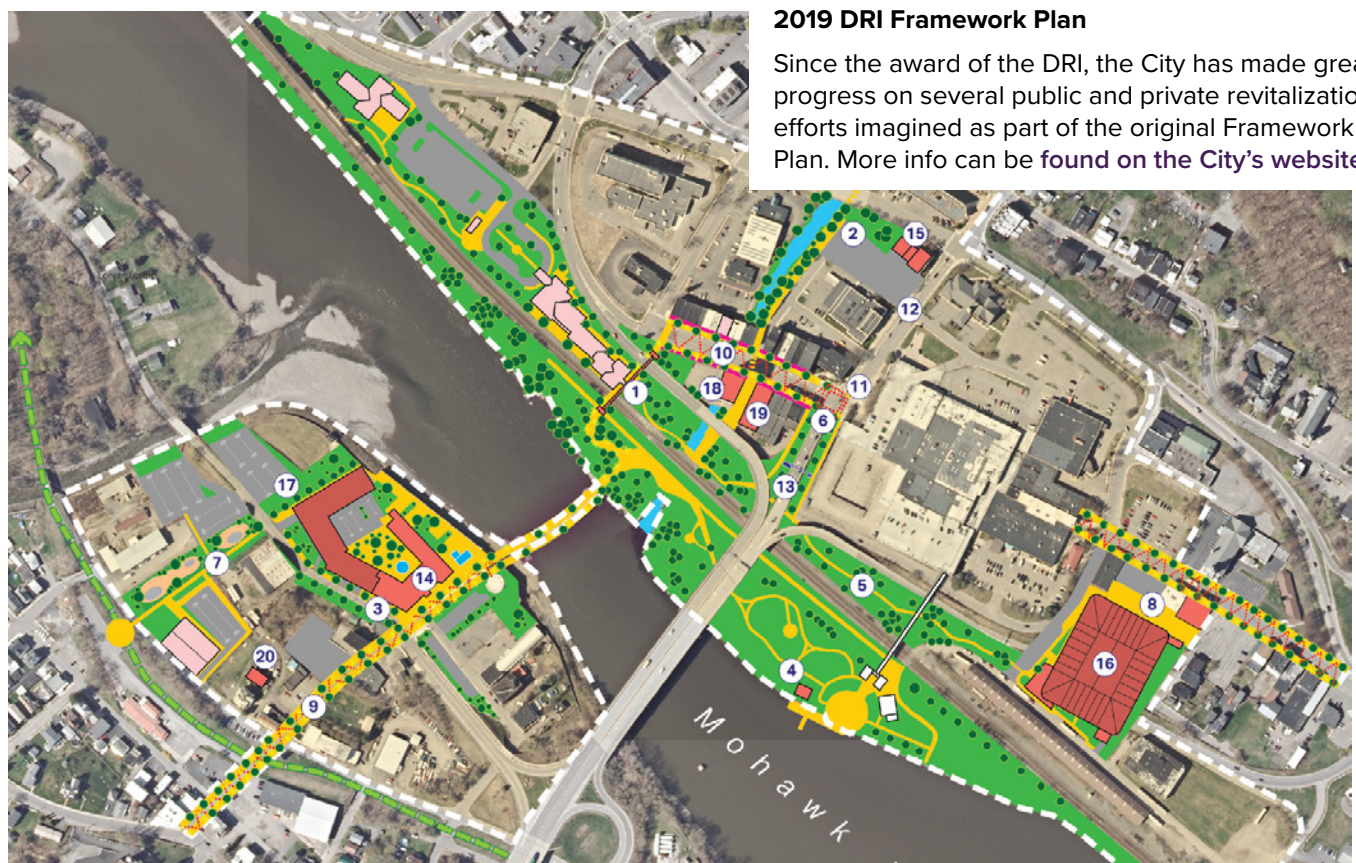
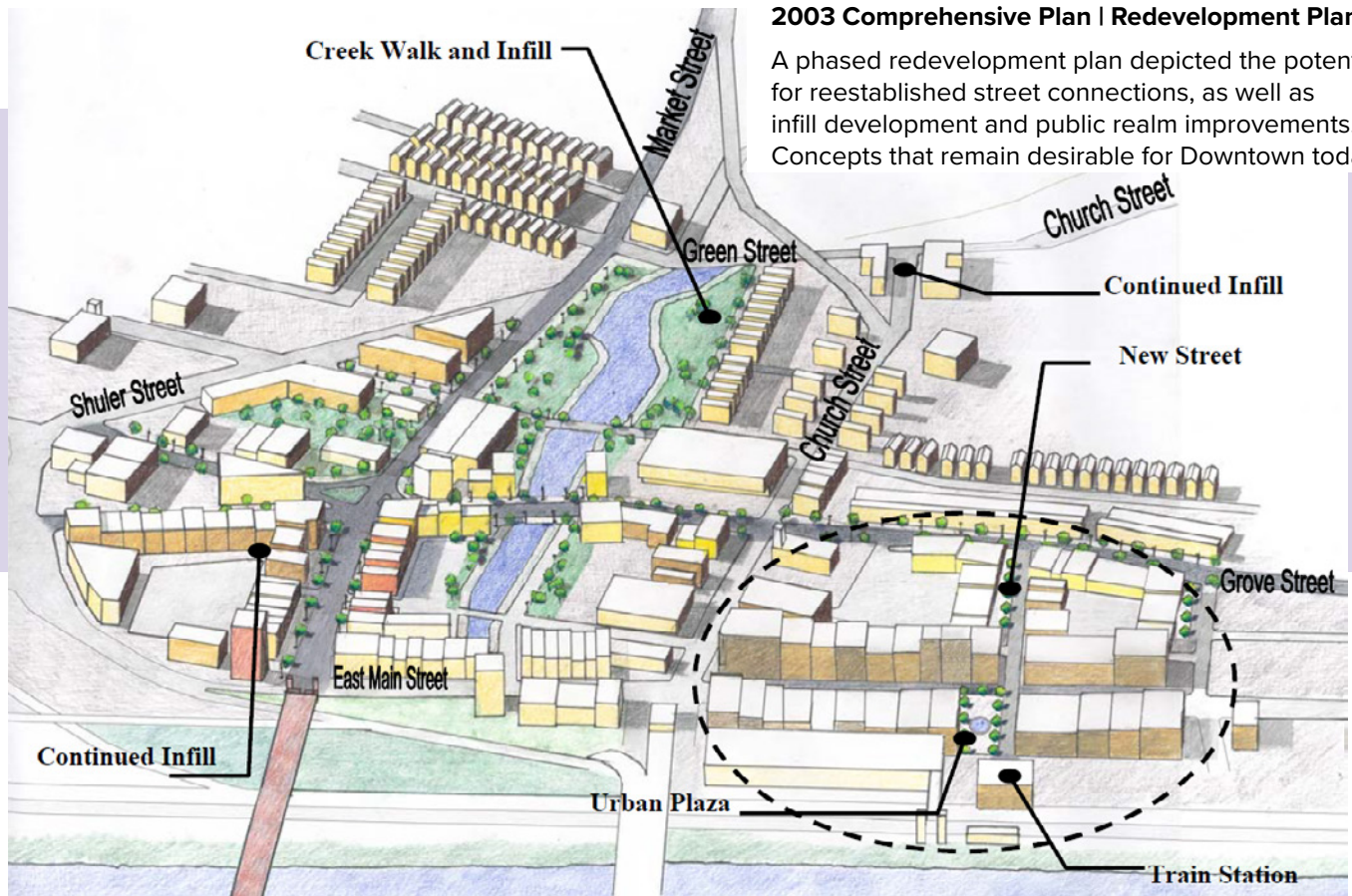


The traditional walkability and character of this segment of Market Street to the north of the downtown core has eroded overtime into an auto-oriented commercial corridor with a fragmented development pattern. While there is a mix of small businesses, service uses, and residential properties, there are inconsistent building setbacks and limited pedestrian amenities. Many historic properties have been torn down or have lost various architectural details to haphazard facade improvements.

Desired Future Conditions

- Gradual transition of building heights from downtown (minimum 2 stories, maximum 4 stories); compatibility with residential uses
- Redevelopment and infill projects with buildings oriented to the street and little to no setback, following the Form-Based Code Design Standards established for the Downtown Core
- Reduced auto-dominant development pattern by prohibiting auto uses (e.g. gas station, car sales) and requiring parking be located to the side or rear of structures

Downtown Plans Over the Years



COMMUNITY DEVELOPMENT STRATEGY

STRATEGIES TO ENHANCE WALKABILITY & TRANSIT ACCESS

Benefits

- Improves public health through increased physical activity
- Reduces household transportation costs
- Supports small businesses and local economic activity
- Enhances safety by reducing traffic speeds and conflict points
- Lowers greenhouse gas emissions and improves air quality
- Strengthens neighborhood connectivity and social interaction

Land Use & Zoning

- Eliminate or reduce minimum parking requirements in Downtown and mixed-use corridors
- Permit higher residential densities near transit stops
- Require buildings to front sidewalks with parking located to the side or rear
- Create a Transit Oriented Development (TOD) zoning district within a ¼–½ mile radius of the Amtrak station (see next page for more info)

Policy & Incentives

- Offer density bonuses for transit-supportive development
- Provide tax or fee incentives for adaptive reuse projects

Street Design & Infrastructure

- Adopt a formal Complete Streets policy to guide site plan review and capital projects
- Expand sidewalk networks and repair gaps in pedestrian infrastructure
- Install high-visibility crosswalks and pedestrian refuge islands
- Improve lighting and wayfinding to Downtown and waterfront destinations
- Add bicycle lanes, shared-use paths, and secure bike parking

Parking & Access Management

- Encourage shared parking agreements
- Establish parking maximums where appropriate
- Consolidate curb cuts and require cross-access between properties

Adjusting Parking Requirements

Currently, the City of Amsterdam zoning code has minimum parking requirements for all districts except the:

- Downtown Core (DC) District; and
- North Amsterdam and Waterfront Form Based Code Subareas.

The minimum parking requirements outside the above areas are more consistent with a suburban development model. For example, the zoning code requires 1.5+ spaces per dwelling unit and 1 space per 150 sf of retail uses.

The City should expand the regulatory approach of the Downtown Form Based Code North Amsterdam and Waterfront Subareas to apply to all downtown areas and mixed use corridors. This includes:

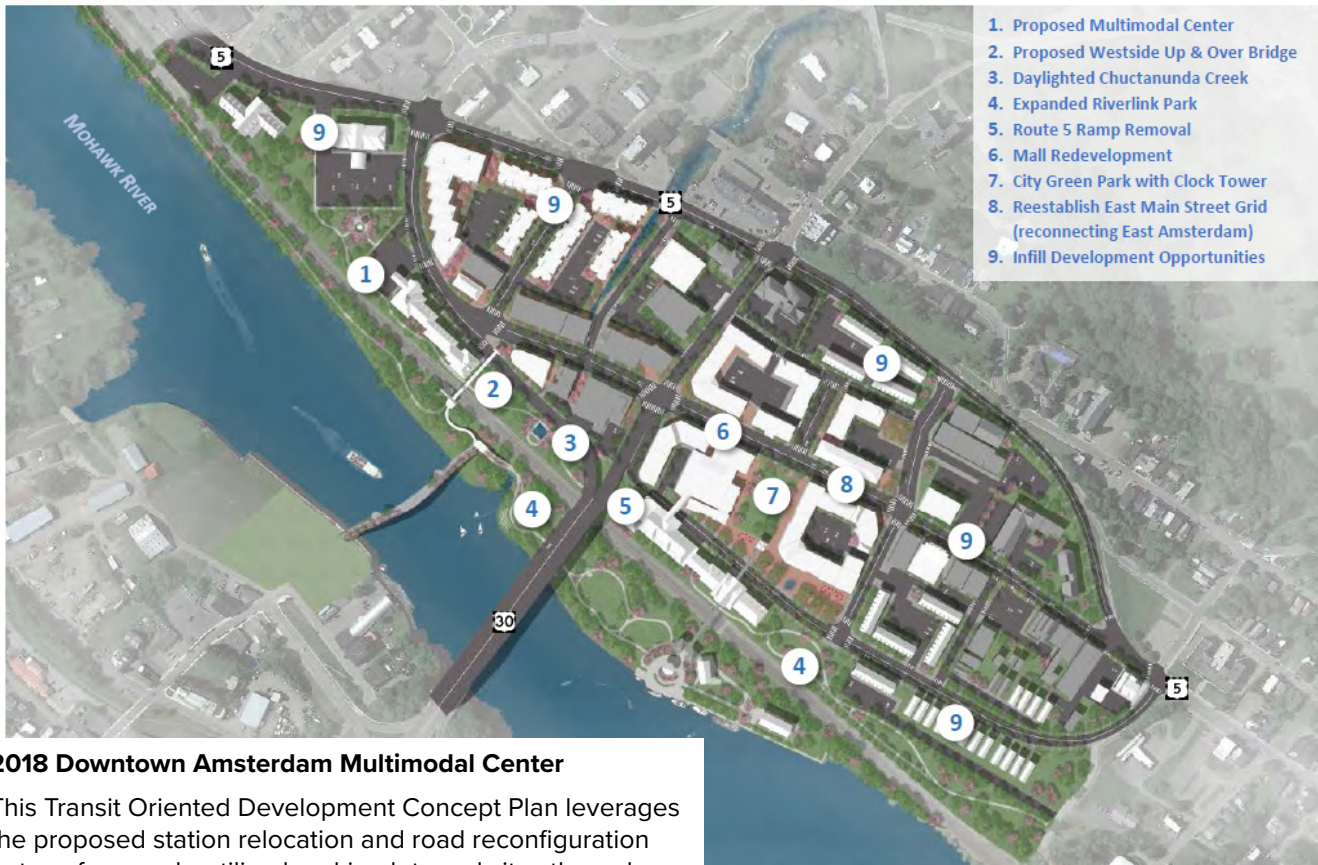
- No minimum parking requirement for existing buildings/uses
- Transportation Demand Management Plan required for new uses/development over 10,000 sf
- Minimum bicycle parking requirements
- Parking landscaping requirements
- Front yard parking prohibited

Transit-Oriented Development (TOD) District Implementation

A Transit-Oriented Development (TOD) district is a zoning area designed to concentrate compact, mixed-use development within walking distance—typically $\frac{1}{4}$ to $\frac{1}{2}$ mile—of a transit station or major transit corridor.

TOD districts promote higher residential densities, active ground-floor uses, reduced parking requirements, and pedestrian-oriented design to encourage transit ridership and reduce reliance on automobiles. By aligning land use, infrastructure, and mobility planning, a TOD district supports economic growth, housing choice, and sustainable development patterns centered around accessible public transportation.

TOD CONCEPT PLAN



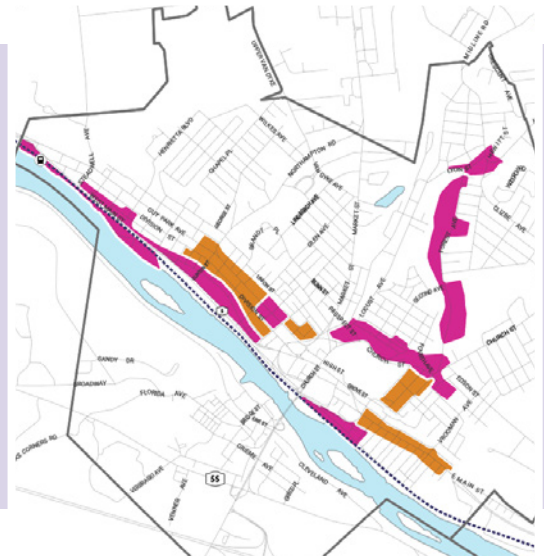
2018 Downtown Amsterdam Multimodal Center

This Transit Oriented Development Concept Plan leverages the proposed station relocation and road reconfiguration to transform underutilized parking lots and sites through targeted infill development and redevelopment projects.

COMMUNITY DEVELOPMENT STRATEGY

Mixed Use Corridors

Mixed-use corridors play a central role in shaping Amsterdam's future by focusing growth, reinvestment, and mobility improvements along key streets that connect neighborhoods, Downtown, employment centers, and community services. These corridors serve as both **economic engines** and **community connectors**, balancing development intensity with neighborhood compatibility.



Neighborhood Commercial

These corridors are distinguished by their walkable streetscapes and mix of commercial uses alongside residential, while still respecting the residential character of the area. Often, these commercial corridors act as a buffer between neighborhoods and higher intensity commercial and industrial uses. Generally, the scale of development is limited, with smaller building footprints and building heights compatible with that of existing homes in the area. While some nonresidential uses occupy structures originally built for commercial or mixed use purposes, several businesses and service uses operate out of converted homes.

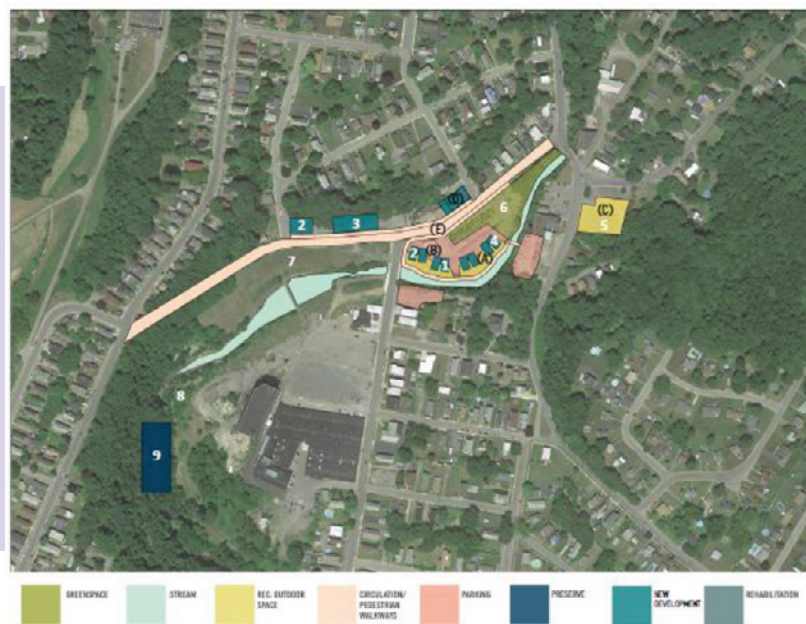
Desired Future Conditions

- Strengthened neighborhood centers with local retail, services, and community uses.
- Sensitive infill that respects neighborhood scale and character (e.g. max 5,000 square foot building footprints, max 3-4 stories, minimal setbacks with landscaped front yards, parking located to side or rear).
- Improved pedestrian environment with sidewalk expansions where gaps may exist.
- Phasing out auto-oriented uses and redevelopment of sites with suburban development patterns (see image below).
- Conversion of residential structures that respects original character of the home and minimizes impact to resident quality of life,



Guy Park Ave looking westward toward McDonnell Street.

The Neighborhood Commercial Mixed Use Corridor Areas are currently regulated by the Downtown Core (DC) and Commercial Corridor (CC) Districts. The DC District is not an appropriate scale for these areas, so rezoning all to the CC District would be more appropriate. However, some modifications to the CC District will be necessary to support the desired development character. Auto-oriented uses should be prohibited and maximum building heights should be reduced from 70 feet to no more than 45 feet.



Northern Neighborhoods BOA

Brownfield Opportunity Area (BOA)

The two largest Mixed Industrial Redevelopment Corridors are located within the Northern Neighborhoods BOA boundary.

Within this study there are recommendations for the transformation and reclamation of contaminated and underutilized sites like the Rockton Gateway (pictured at left). The City should continue to pursue the realization of these plans to support its future land use goals.

Mixed Industrial Redevelopment



Vacant industrial building.



Large setback and curbcuts erode traditional character.

The mixed industrial redevelopment corridors are envisioned to support less intense uses than those in the larger-scale industry centers, while also providing for creative building and site reuse efforts that cultivate mixed use activity with increased housing, retail, and service operations. Primarily, these corridors target areas with a concentration of legacy industrial buildings and sites that may be underutilized, vacant, and/or in a state of decline. The mixed industrial redevelopment corridors abutting the existing rail line also serve as a buffer to the adjacent neighborhoods, while still allowing for low intensity and limited industrial and commercial activity that leverages the direct access to and location along Route 5.

Today's markets continue to favor flexible, lower-cost space for light manufacturing, maker/creative spaces, warehousing, and small business expansion—especially where highway access and utilities already exist. Larger structures can also support phased adaptive reuse (including multi-tenant employment space, commercial services, live-work units, etc). These areas offer high redevelopment potential as “ready-made” investment areas where strategic site assembly, brownfield cleanup, and upgraded multimodal connections can convert underutilized land into job-generating, mixed-use environments. To ensure existing and future residential uses are not negatively impacted, certain transitional treatments and context sensitive design elements may be necessary with future investment.

Desired Future Conditions

- Dynamic corridors with mixed employment, commercial, and residential activity where the historic variation in building size, design, style, and use is celebrated.
- Creative, adaptive reuse of existing historic structures, where feasible.
- Integration of green infrastructure and public access to adjacent greenways.
- Improved streetscapes and facades, promoting walkability and multi-modal access.

These corridors are currently regulated by the Commercial Corridor and Employment Districts. The City should consider adapting the Employment District to serve as a Mixed Industry / Redevelopment District for these areas. Potential amendments may include: Reduced minimum lot width, reduced front setback, increased building coverage, and increased building height (in a manner sensitive to the context of adjacent properties).

COMMUNITY DEVELOPMENT STRATEGY

Industry Centers

Regional commerce, industrial, and medical activity centers play a critical role in the City of Amsterdam by anchoring employment, supporting a diverse economic base, and providing essential services that serve both city residents and the broader Mohawk Valley. These centers attract regional investment, sustain jobs across a range of skill levels, and strengthen the City's fiscal capacity while reducing the need for residents to travel outside the community for healthcare, goods, and services.



Regional Commerce

The regional commerce area is a hub of large-scale commercial, lodging, travel-based, and industrial activity that caters to the traveling public as it as immediate and direct access to several major roadways, including I-90, Route 5S, and Route 30. This area is distinguished from the rest of the City in that it was developed in response to the widespread reliance on cars and semi-trucks for personal and commercial transportation. As a result, the area has high vehicular access and visibility, with limited internal connectivity between sites, low development efficiency, and significant areas of impervious surface. It is both visually and physically disconnected from downtown Amsterdam.

Desired Future Conditions

- Modernized employment and commercial hub supporting regional economic activity
- Improved internal circulation, shared access, and coordinated site design
- Opportunities for mixed commercial, flex-industrial, and supportive services
- Direct access from local transit services
- Integration of green infrastructure and site design practices that maximize the preservation of natural areas and mitigate stormwater impacts
- Increased wayfinding and multi-modal access to downtown to support local tourism



Medical Campus Case Study

Providence Community Health District plan for a 132-acre medical campus dominated by surface parking lots near downtown Providence, Rhode Island.

The CNU Legacy Project team proposes transforming the parking area into a mixed-use neighborhood with new housing units, retail, hospitality, and green spaces. The plan aims to create walkable connections between major employment centers while maintaining necessary parking in concealed structures.

The context sensitive design also helps to ensure appropriate buffers and transitions to adjacent neighborhoods.

Source: DPZ CoDesign

Medical Campus

The Medical Campus area is intended to support the long-term modernization and expansion of healthcare, research, and related services in a coordinated campus setting while remaining compatible with adjacent residential neighborhoods. This area has the potential to support a mix of clinical, employment, and support uses organized around shared open space, internal circulation, and high-quality design. Development within the campus should function as a cohesive district that enhances healthcare access, supports local employment, and minimizes land use conflicts through thoughtful transitions and buffering.

The City should evaluate the extent of the Medical Residential Neighborhood District boundaries and incorporate campus style design considerations.

Elements of Campus Design

- Height and massing transitions adjacent to residential areas, including step-backs and lower building heights at edges
- Landscaped buffers, tree canopy, and screening along neighborhood-facing boundaries
- Internal street networks and pedestrian connections rather than single large blocks
- Shared parking structures and limited surface parking along public streets
- Coordinated wayfinding and design plans to direct visitors to parking, services, etc.
- Direct, multi-modal access, including leveraging nearby transit stations (bus and rail)

Light Industrial

Despite its name, the Light Industrial areas are the largest scale active industrial and manufacturing operations in the City located near the rail line and utility infrastructure along Highway 5. The area to the north of Highway 5 is largely isolated, as it is surrounded by woodlots and greenspace. The area south of Highway 5 is more developed and directly abuts residences to the west.

Desired Future Conditions

- Continued support for modern industrial and advanced manufacturing uses
- Ample buffering and transitions to residential, as well as screening of parking, loading, and outdoor operations from the public right-of-way
- Preserved natural areas and incorporation of green infrastructure
- Limited outdoor operations, especially where adjacent to residential uses

COMMUNITY DEVELOPMENT STRATEGY

Natural Environment

The City is shaped by the Mohawk River, associated floodplains, steep slopes, and wooded hillsides that define its historic settlement pattern and continue to influence where and how development can occur. These natural features constrain development in some areas while creating strong opportunities for recreation and tourism in others. Protecting water resources, managing flood risk, and integrating green infrastructure into redevelopment efforts will be essential to guiding future land use that is both environmentally resilient and economically productive.



Parks & Greenspace

These areas include the various trail segments, parks, natural areas, and open spaces across the City, including the undisturbed woodlots and conserved lands with limited or restricted development potential. While there is some connectivity between these greenspaces via trails and on-street pedestrian connections, the overall “greenway” network is fragmented, lacking continuous public access.

Topography and drainage patterns limit large-scale greenfield development while reinforcing the importance of compact growth, reinvestment, and adaptive reuse within already developed areas. Steep slopes and erosion-prone areas constrain intensive development but provide opportunities for scenic open space, green infrastructure, and trail connections that enhance neighborhood quality of life.

Environmental features such as floodplains, wetlands, and riparian corridors play a critical role in stormwater management, habitat protection, and climate resilience, shaping future land use by encouraging preservation and low-impact uses along waterways. Together, these natural resources support a land use strategy focused on waterfront revitalization, greenways and blueways, and targeted redevelopment that balances economic growth with environmental stewardship and long-term resilience.

Although addressed independently as a CDS character area, the future use and preservation of these spaces should be integrated into the planning and investment of the other character areas which they surround and abut.

Key Strategies to Leverage Parks & Greenspaces

- **Downtown & Main Street Transition:** Riverfront promenades, trail connections, and public spaces supporting economic activity and tourism.
- **Mixed Use Industrial Redevelopment:** Blueway-oriented redevelopment that incorporates public access, green buffers, and stormwater management.
- **Residential Neighborhoods:** Neighborhood-scale greenway connections improving walkability, health, and quality of life.
- **Regional Connectivity:** Linkages to regional trail systems, waterways, and open space networks to strengthen Amsterdam’s role as a gateway community.

Tree Canopy Benefits & Opportunities

Amsterdam's urban tree canopy provides shade, improves air quality, reduces heat island effects, and helps manage stormwater.

The City should consider taking steps to further protect and expand its tree canopy through strategic planting, preservation, and replanting efforts to enhance tree equity and resiliency.

These efforts may help sustain canopy levels along streets and throughout residential neighborhoods, further leveraging the ecological, societal, and economic benefits.

Today,

1,413 acres or about 38% of Amsterdam's land area is covered by trees. Every year, this tree canopy provides the following:



\$958,992
of economic benefits



5,173 tons
of CO₂ equivalent
sequestered



58,762 pounds
of air pollutants removed



15 mil. gallons
of avoided runoff



23 Olympic pools
of rainfall absorbed by tree roots
and kept out of storm sewers

Tomorrow...

a 10% increase or about 141 acres of added canopy area would add the following in tree benefits:



\$34,852
of economic benefits



5,556 tons
of carbon stored



6,688 pounds
of air pollutants removed



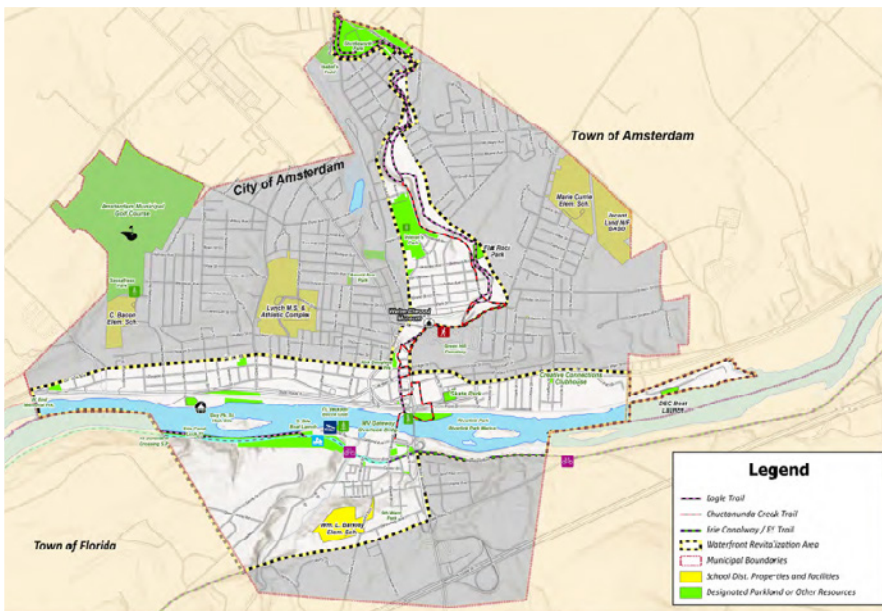
1.5 mil. gallons
of avoided runoff



Try it for yourself!

This data was generated by iTree, a free tool from USFS that estimates tree canopies and benefits. Visit itreetools.org for more info!

COMMUNITY DEVELOPMENT STRATEGY

**WRA Waterfront Revitalization Area**

Within the City's Local Waterfront Revitalization Program (LWRP) is a defined Waterfront Revitalization Area (WRA). The map at left from the LWRP Study shows the extent of the WRA in white.

These water resources are inextricably linked to the parks, open space, and recreational assets within the City. Together, they may create a network of greenways and blueways throughout Amsterdam that not only connect people to nature, but also serve a myriad of economic, health, and ecological benefits.

Waterfront & Blueways

These areas include the Mohawk River and associated streams, floodplains, and waterfront lands that together define a natural framework of blueways across the City. These are important areas to consider as part of the CDS as they are ecologically sensitive, subject to flooding, erosion, and water quality concerns. However, they also present great opportunities for increased connection between neighborhoods and activity centers to the Mohawk River through public access, trails, and water-based recreation. Future land use along these corridors can support mixed-use redevelopment, tourism, and environmental restoration while preserving floodplains as functional open space. By integrating blueways with green infrastructure and walkable development, the waterfront can serve as both an economic asset and a resilient natural system.

City of Amsterdam | Local Waterfront Revitalization Program (LWRP)

The City's LWRP should be considered an integrated part of this CDS, helping to guide future investment and decision-making for all areas within the Waterfront Revitalization Area (WRA). All future actions should be evaluated for consistency with the LWRP policies in accordance with Chapter 241 (Waterfront Revitalization) of the City of Amsterdam Code. There are a total of 44 policies outlined in the LWRP, covering 11 general areas of concern. This includes:

- Development Policies (1-6)
- Fish and Wildlife Policies (7-10)
- Flooding and Erosion Hazards Policies (11-17)
- General Policy (18)
- Public Access Policies (19 and 10)
- Recreation Policies (21 and 22)
- Historic and Scenic Resources Policies (23-25)
- Agricultural Lands Policy (26)
- Energy and Ice Management Policies (27-29)
- Water and Air Resources Policies (30-43)
- Wetlands Policy (44)

AMSTERDAM'S SUCCESSES

Recent Projects Building Investment Momentum

Overview

Since the completion of the Pedestrian Bridge, the City of Amsterdam has experienced meaningful momentum in economic development, placemaking, and private investment.

Southside / Fifth Ward Revitalization

The Southside has seen notable restaurant growth, including Lorenzo's Italian Restaurant and L'Ultimo, both family-operated establishments that attract strong regional followings. The historic Armory building has undergone significant private reinvestment and now offers boutique accommodations and elegant dining space. The annual Italian Festival continues to be a well-attended and celebrated community tradition.

Riverfront & Riverlink Park

Riverfront development has strengthened the connection between Downtown and the Southside. Riverlink Park now hosts regular live music events, annual cultural festivals, and fireworks displays, drawing residents and visitors alike. Public art installations and ongoing volunteer efforts by the Riverlink Committee have enhanced the waterfront as a major community asset.

Recent and Ongoing Development Projects

- Amsterdam Municipal Golf Club – A new state-of-the-art facility expected to open in Fall 2025
- Senior Housing on Edwards Street – New 55+ rental development currently under construction
- Aurora Development (East Main Street) – Approved mixed-use rehabilitation restoring historic architecture
- Boogie Lab Bakery & Brewery (Forest Avenue) – Planned European-inspired bakery and brewery concept
- Creekside Restaurant – A popular dining destination off Forest Avenue
- Chad Majewski Realty – Redevelopment of a former gas station into a modern commercial space
- Lyon Street Bar & Grill – Revitalization of a formerly struggling restaurant
- Lusso Motors & Auto Sales (2024) – Renovation of an older building into a high-quality auto sales facility

These investments reflect growing confidence in the City's future.

LOOKING FORWARD

Amsterdam possesses strong assets: its waterfront, rail access, proximity to Saratoga, Albany, and a regional airport, and a community that takes pride in itself.

The next strategic challenge is attracting higher-end residential development and expanded housing options.

Other communities have successfully repositioned themselves and exploring similar strategies may help Amsterdam build on its current momentum.



Edward Street Senior Housing Project Rendering

End of Draft Plan